

Prologue

The revolution devours its children. — Jacques Mallet du Pan

December 30, 1983

Bridgeport, New York

A December wind was coming off the ice of Oneida Lake and finding its way through the walls of the old house on Fisher's Bay. The devotion candle on the mantel kept bending in the drafts—blue at the base, orange in the middle, a thin white tip. Above the candle, under an old crucifix, the icons of Jesus and Mary looked down on the room.

We knelt in a half-circle around the hearth—my father and mother, my sisters, and me—the living room dark except for the candle. Our voices rose and fell on the family Rosary, the Hail Marys coming out in the rhythm we had been saying them most nights that year. On the wall above us, the Sacred Heart of Jesus and the Immaculate Heart of Mary looked down from their frames with the same tired weight I could see on my parents' faces.

I was ten. Kneeling in place was a trial at that age. My patience frayed most when my father, in his fervor, extended the end of the Rosary with a litany of saints.

"St. Damien, pray for us..."

"St. Hubert, pray for us..."

"St. Philomena, pray for us..."

His petitions seemed endless. These were strangers to me, their stories unknown. I wondered: Why isn't Jesus and Mary enough? Why all these others? My father said

being Catholic was to enter into the Communion of Saints—that they were our advocates, our family. I understood it. It did not make the litany shorter.

When the final prayers faded, we scrambled up from our knees, a flurry of small bodies vying for the honor of blowing out the candle. The trembling flame on the mantel was the prize for every soul under eight.

"Mom, can I blow it out?" Violet pleaded, as my father intoned the Sign of the Cross to seal the Rosary.

"In the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Spirit."

"Yes, dear," my mother said.

"That's not fair! She asked before we were done!" Nellie protested, leaping up to puff out the flame before Violet could reach it.

"Mooooom!" Violet wailed.

"Mary, stop it." My mother's voice was sharp.

"Do you all want to hear a story?" my father said.

My heart sank. I wanted to get back to the hypnotic glow of my game of Mario Bros. And I still held a grudge from the last time my father had told a post-Rosary tale, three years before—the night he had spun the story of St. Nicholas only to reveal that there was no "Santa Claus" as we had known him. Reindeer, sleigh, elves—all a grand illusion. Christmas had not looked the same since.

My sisters clapped eagerly.

"Yes!" Marie chirped.

"Yes!" Nellie echoed.

My father had a gift for stories. In those moments, and when he talked about the Faith, he was fully present to us—not the Union Business Manager taking calls from out-of-work members late into the evening, but our father. To see him speaking about his faith with that kind of conviction inspired us.

"Have you heard of Rasputin, the Mad Monk?" he began.

"No," we answered in unison—me, Marie, Mary, and Violet.

"Today marks the anniversary of his death."

"That's sad," Violet said, barely four.

My father chuckled. "Not so sad, honey. Rasputin was an evil man. They called him the Mad Monk because he played a key role in the fall of the Russian Empire, which unleashed the evils that haunt us now."

He struck a new match and relit the candle Nellie had just blown out. The glow climbed the wall.

"Some say Rasputin wasn't mad at all—that he was possessed by demons, a pawn of Satan sowing chaos. The story begins about sixty years ago with Czar Nicholas and Empress Alexandra, Russia's royal family—the Romanovs. The Romanovs carried a curse from intermarriage. Royals used to marry their relatives to keep the bloodline pure, but that practice brought with it the plague of hemophilia."

"Marrying family? Like brothers and sisters?" I asked, wrinkling my nose.

"Ewww," Marie added.

"Not quite. Cousins wed cousins."

"What is hemophilia, Dad?"

"It's a blood disorder. If you get a cut, your body can't coagulate the blood. You can bleed to death."

"Yuck." Nellie scrunched up her nose.

"Their youngest child, Alexei, was the heir to his father's throne. He had the disease. His mother was so desperate to find him a cure she opened herself to any means of healing. She sent her advisors out across the country. That opened the door to Rasputin, who had a reputation as a mystic and a healer. When the Empress brought him to court, he managed to heal Alexei when no one else could."

"If he was evil, how did he heal him?"

"Well—devils are angels too. They are very powerful."

"Rasputin used the healing to gain favor. The Empress thought he was sent by God and made him her confidant. When the Czar went off to fight in World War I, Rasputin's shadow grew. He used his influence to put his own allies into positions of authority. Rumors of his immoral life fueled resentment against the monarchy. The rumors spread like wildfire and damaged the reputation of the Czar."

"Why?"

"Because the war made life very hard. There weren't many jobs. People were starving. Russians were a pious people. When they heard this man was ruling Russia through the Empress, they lost confidence in their Emperor. The nobles saw him as a threat to the monarchy. He was unraveling Russia and empowering the Bolsheviks."

My father's voice dropped. "Loyalists resolved to kill Rasputin. They invited him to dinner and laced his wine with enough cyanide to kill an elephant. To their amazement, he kept eating and drinking as though nothing was wrong. The poison didn't faze him. One of the conspirators grew impatient, pretended he had to go to the bathroom, got

up, walked behind Rasputin, and shot him in the back. Rasputin got up and tried to flee. They shot him a dozen more times. He fell. The men gathered around, sure he was dead. Then, to their horror, he rose again and tried to flee again. They had to keep fighting to subdue him. He fought his way outside. Only outside did they finally overtake him. They tied him up, put him in a burlap sack, and threw him into an icy river.

"The next morning, the police found his body frozen on the shore. He had somehow escaped from the sack, crawled onto the bank, and finally died of the cold. The poison, the bullets, the beating—none of it had been enough."

We sat still. The candle flickered in our eyes.

"That's scary," Marie whispered.

"I don't understand," I said. "Why didn't the poison or the bullets kill him?"

"Some say he was possessed," my father said. "The devil was animating him, using him to create chaos—so that the Russian people would accept the Bolshevik Revolution and topple the Czar."

"What are Bolsheviks?" Marie asked.

"They were Communists. They began the Russian Revolution that October. They were responsible for the tide of bloodshed that was unleashed on the world."

A chill came over me. We sat in silence for a long moment.

"But that same October," my father went on, "God sent his Mother from heaven to counter this evil. In Fatima, Portugal, Our Lady appeared to three shepherd children and gave them the greatest miracle witnessed in modern times—the Miracle of the Sun. On October 13, 1917, while the Bolsheviks were rising, a hundred thousand people gathered in a rain-soaked field in Portugal because the three children had said the Lady

was going to give them a sign. The clouds parted. The sun danced in the sky and seemed to plunge toward the earth. Everyone there fell to the ground, thinking it was the end of the world."

"What was the miracle for?" I asked.

"So that people would believe the message from heaven. The three secrets she told the children."

"What secrets?"

My father pointed to the window, where snowflakes were swirling in the lamplight. "Our Lady told the three shepherd children—(Sister) Lucia, Francisco, and Jacinta—that sins of the flesh were dragging souls to Hell, like those snowflakes falling. Unless the world converted, many more souls would fall. Lucia, the oldest, said they would have died of fright if the Lady had not first told them they would all go to heaven. Then Our Lady showed them a vision of Hell. Her second secret warned there would be a second great war if the world did not repent—and she warned that Russia would spread her errors."

"What errors?"

"Most people said it was Communism. The real error Russia spread was atheism. When God is removed from a country, every man becomes a god unto himself. That's why Communism has killed over a hundred million people and persecuted the Church."

"And the third secret..." He paused. "It's half-known. The only thing we know for certain is what Sister Lucia wrote. The dogma of the faith will be preserved in Portugal—dot, dot, dot." He pointed at the air for each dot, marking the ellipsis in Lucia's writing. "She spoke of the faith enduring in Portugal. That's a hint at the crisis we are in now."

"Why don't we know by now?"

"Well, that's the million-dollar question. Our Lady ordered the Vatican to reveal it by 1960. But Pope John XXIII read it and said the message wasn't for our time."

"I don't understand why the Pope wouldn't reveal it."

"At that time, many believed the Third Secret foretold a great apostasy that would come. This was when Pope John XXIII was in the middle of planning Second Vatican Council. They didn't want to believe it was true. The Church was infiltrated by Communists and Freemasons, and they used the Council to introduce heresy and bring about a great apostasy. That's why we pray the Rosary every night. That's why we go to the Latin Mass.

"Our Lady warned that the final battle between the Lord and the kingdom of Satan would be over marriage and the family. Those are the evils plaguing us now. She said a great tribulation would befall the world if the Pope and the bishops did not consecrate Russia to her Immaculate Heart as she had asked. Sister Lucia said the Pope would eventually do it, but late."

"What's a tribulation?" Nellie asked.

"Something like nuclear war."

"When will the Pope and the bishops do the Consecration?" I asked. I was hoping a remedy was right around the corner.

"Time will tell. Time will tell."

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Later that night I lay in bed and tried to put my father's story out of my head. I could not. The word tribulation stayed. I thought about nuclear war. I stared into the

dark of my bedroom, and the sounds of objects flying overhead outside—far away, above the house—pierced the silence of the night sky.

Is that a nuclear missile? I thought.

I could not tell the difference between an intercontinental ballistic missile and a jetliner carrying retired snowbirds fleeing the cold, gray Syracuse winter for their winter houses in Florida. My whole body was full of dread that at any moment one of those sounds would be a missile, and a missile would come down on our house, and then there would be hell on earth, and possibly an eternity in Hell after that. Ever since we had started going to the Latin Mass offered by the priests of the Society of St. Pius X, everything had seemed bleak to me—a departure from what I had known before.

The TV film *The Day After* had aired a few weeks earlier. I had seen it. The pale, sickly people losing their hair from radiation sickness played over and over in the theater of my imagination, and the strangers' faces kept being replaced by the faces of my parents and my sisters.

Radiation poisoning was an evil my young mind could grasp because I could see it. The real evil was more insidious, and I was too young to recognize it. My father had told us of Our Lady's warning—that Russia would spread her errors. Neither he nor I understood the breadth or depth of it. It would not be nuclear bombs and radiation that would tear apart my family and my world. It would not be radical ideology either. It would be fear. The thought of these tribulations filled me with dread. My only comfort that night was whispering Hail Marys to myself, one after another, until I fell asleep.

Chapter 1

All The King's Men

In war, truth is the first casualty. — Aeschylus

February 8, 2023

Front Royal, Virginia

The television was on and I was half-watching a college basketball game from the couch when my phone went off. The R2-D2 whistle of my ringtone cut through the crowd noise. Seamus Conor. My old high school buddy from St. Mary's Academy, the traditional Catholic boarding school in Kansas run by the Priestly Fraternity of the Society of Saint Pius X.

He had sent a screenshot before calling. Tucker Carlson on Fox News, in his stern face, interviewing a former FBI agent named Kyle Seraphin. Across the bottom, a chyron in bold letters: "FBI Targeting Catholics Who Attend Latin Mass." My interest in the game vanished. I hit call and switched the channel to Fox.

Seamus picked up without a greeting, in his Philly accent. "Is that one of your buddies from Richmond?"

"Never saw the guy in my life. What's going on?"

"Turn on the news. Someone inside the FBI leaked that agents are spying on Trads in Richmond."

I was already on it. Carlson and Seraphin were framing the leak as the Biden-era FBI hunting for right-wing extremists among Traditional Catholics in Richmond, Virginia.

"Whoa."

"Isn't that the parish you and Allison went to when you lived in Richmond?"

"St. Joseph's? Sometimes," I said. My wife Allison and I had lived in Richmond for years. St. Joseph's, her parents' parish, was the first diocesan parish in the United States established exclusively to offer the Traditional Latin Mass—a sanctuary for the old Catholic ritual alone. It was old time Catholicism: Latin, the dead language of antiquity, the only liturgical language suitable for Traditional Catholics.

In 1965, Pope Paul VI and the hierarchy of the Catholic Church reformed Catholic Sunday worship so that the Mass was more accessible to the faithful, translating the prayers from Latin into the vernacular—the common language of each country. In the early 1970s, a lone bishop with a handful of priests and seminarians refused the reforms, holding that the new Missal—the Novus Ordo—as not only inferior to the old Tridentine rite but contended it was damaging the faith of those who said it and attended it. For them it was "too watered down." Some believed it was part of a Satanic plan hatched by Freemasons and Communists to subvert the Church from within.

"Why would the FBI be spying on parishioners at St. Joe's?" I asked.

"For starters, I don't think the Biden administration needs good reasons. Anything connected to MAGA has a bullseye on it."

"I'm guessing it has something to do with Steve Bannon."

"Steve Bannon, Trump's guy?"

"Yeah. His father, Marty, was a parishioner at St. Joseph's."

"His dad's a Traddy?"

"He went to the Latin Mass every Sunday. I don't think he would have called himself a Traddy. Marty served on the finance council with my father-in-law."

"So he isn't one of those conspiracy guys like your Cousin Al?"

I kept my tone light. "No. Marty wasn't stockpiling weapons, if that's what you're getting at. He just liked the old Mass. He has to be in his mid-eighties."

"Maybe Team Biden's harassing Bannon's family."

"Sloppy Steve's gonna make the Latin Mass greeeeeeaaat aaagaaain," I said, doing my best Trump imitation.

Seamus snorted. "Leave the Trump impressions to Alec Baldwin. Anyway, Bannon's not in Trump's inner circle anymore."

"No, but he's been on his podcast every day hammering Biden."

"So—you and Allison weren't regulars at the Latin Mass down there?" Seamus's voice went sly.

"Sometimes," I said.

"Sometimes? You embracing the Spirit of Vatican II now, Louie?"

"All right, if you must know, I've been working on my jazz hands for the liturgical dance at next week's clown Mass."

I knew every strawman argument Traditionalists had against mainstream Catholic parishes. Growing up, we had been led to believe the new Mass after Vatican II was not even valid consecration of the bread and wine into the body and blood of Jesus, that is to say, many Traditional Catholics were led to believe that every Novus Ordo was a liturgical dumpster fire, that attending was at best spiritually dangerous and at worst a kind of sacrilege. I had left those categories behind. I was not in the mood to relitigate them with Seamus.

"I bet you'd fit right in at a clown Mass," he said, laughing.

The jab stung, though I grinned. "Our pastor, Fr. Kauffmann, encouraged teachers at St. Benedict's to show up for Sunday Mass as often as possible. Said it encouraged the students."

"Tell him the kids would probably avoid Mass if they saw you there."

"That hurts, man." I feigned offense. "That hurts."

He chuckled. His tone shifted. "Look, I go to the Novus Ordo now and then. I just can't stomach it. If I hear another pitchy middle-aged soprano warbling 'Knock, Knock, Knockin' on Heaven's Door' during the Offertory, I'll commit Harry Caray." Hearing Seamus admit he attended the Novus Ordo would have been anathema to our peers back in high school. Who would dare attend a sacrilege? I knew the rhetoric came out of the same well both of us had been drawing from for thirty years.

"I've gotta say," I answered, "somewhere Bishop Williamson is smiling, knowing there's still ONE, TRUE, CATHOLIC in the world. If only more people were as faithful as you, Seamus." I kept my delivery wet with sarcasm.

He cut through it. "Stop. I don't care where you go to Mass, Louie. I'm just glad you still go. Half the guys from our class have ditched the Church entirely."

"Can you blame them?" I said, and I felt the old darkness tightening in my chest. "Learning that the man who ran your high school was accused of raping a Mexican boy does not tend to foster piety."

"Don't go there, Louie."

"Okay. Sorry, not sorry. But how many people have to abandon their faith before we admit that the SSPX isn't the solution to the problem—they're just one part of it? How many stories have to crawl across your ticker before you look at it straight?"

"The problem with my classmates is they were too smart for their own good. It wasn't just Fr. Angles."

"Too smart? You don't think the rape allegations against Angles matter?"

"Louie, we didn't know about any of that till long after we left."

"Okay—what about him showing Nazi propaganda films? Hiring a suspected pedophile? Did that have anything to do with our friends losing their faith?"

Seamus raised his voice. "I didn't text you to start an argument about St. Mary's. I take the good with the bad. Those were the best four years of my life. I wouldn't trade them for anything."

"No one is asking you to burn your yearbooks. But every time I talk about it you stick your head in the sand."

"I told you—I would not put it past him. If he could try to destroy your soul and Brennan's, it is not a stretch. But I don't want any part of your book. It's all you've been talking about lately."

"Maybe that's because they've been nothing but a curse in my life. They took everything I ever cared about and twisted it."

"Listen, Louie, calm down. I'm not saying you don't have reasons to be upset. I just don't want any part of your crusade."

The line went quiet. I flipped the TV to Fox News. Seraphin was still talking. I let Seamus ramble about Mass attendance and watched the chyron at the bottom of the screen.

"Wait—they're not talking about St. Joe's in Richmond. They're talking about the SSPX chapel there."

"The Society has a chapel in Richmond?"

"Yeah. This makes more sense. Looks like the Society has just graduated from Michael Voris and Church Militant to Fox News."

"I hope you're not thinking about putting this in your book."

"And if I do?"

Another long pause. "You do you, Louie. Just leave me out of it."

"Fair enough."

Another long, awkward pause.

"Things better between you and your family?"

"No. This is my point. All these people talk, talk, talk about the true faith—but they have no charity. Things will never be the same with my family again."

"Well, Louie, like I said before, you've only lost what you never had. Your old man is living in his own world."

I was not in the mood to hear judgment passed on who my father was. I knew who he was. Good and bad.

"I gotta run, man. Bedtime for the kids."

"Be good, Louie."

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I hung up and turned off the television. The room was suddenly quiet in a way that made the quiet louder. An old anger stirred.

Three years earlier, in the spring of 2020 during the COVID lockdowns, a Catholic outlet had broken the story of a young woman from St. Mary's, Kansas, who accused

SSPX leadership of covering up sexual abuse. The reporting's central subject was Fr. Ramon Angles, my former headmaster. For years I had been working to overcome the anger that had almost destroyed me. I had thought all that pain was behind me.

It was not.

This time I could not blame Angles. I could not blame myself. I blamed my father. The Traditional Catholic world that had formed my way of seeing was imploding—and it was not only *my* world. The whole country felt fractured. MAGA, COVID, the shutdowns, the George Floyd riots, January 6, Pope Francis's crackdown on the Latin Mass, and now this—SSPX parishioners on the FBI's radar.

The hardest part was that I had heard this kind of thing before. In 1993 I had refused to believe it, and refusing had cost me dearly. Now, for whatever reason, it seemed to me that God had removed the obstacles and the biases that had prevented me from seeing. I knew better now. History was repeating itself.

The harder part was that I knew I was jaded. My love for my family and my community had once blinded me. Now my heart was heavy with grief and resentment. Was that, too, clouding my judgment?

In a span of thirteen months I had lost two siblings, a nephew, and my mother. Those losses paled beside the conflict tearing the rest of my family apart. A sequence of events had dissolved the bonds of charity that had held us together. I could not help believing it would not have happened if my mother were still alive.

The SSPX militancy claim was the cherry on top. Of course they were in the news. I conjured one of my last memories of my mother—her voice on the phone in December of 2020, after the election. "Louie, we have to fight. We have to fight." She was convinced Joe Biden had stolen the election from Donald Trump. Her voice was full of righteous fury.

"Mom—fight who? Fight where? Fight how?"

I paraphrased the line from *A Man for All Seasons*, where Thomas More confronts William Roper's declaration that he would cut down every law in England to get at the devil. We are a nation of laws, I told her. If we cut down the laws to get at the devil, where will we hide, with all the laws being laid flat, when he turns on us?

The words did not soothe her. Rarely did my mother step out of line from my father's view. That call drove another wedge between us. It was one of many that marked the final two years before she was gone.

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The R2-D2 whistle chirped again. Allison's text: Need help with bath time.

I trudged upstairs, the creak of the wooden steps matching the heaviness in my chest. Steam was rising from the tub where Eddie and Betty, our two- and four-year-olds, splashed each other without a care. I knelt by the tub, the water soaking my sleeves, and washed their small limbs. Their laughter lifted something in me.

My phone was on the counter. I could not resist. I typed FBI Richmond into the search bar and went headfirst down the rabbit hole.

The conservative news sphere was on fire with the story. Kyle Seraphin had leaked an internal memo from the FBI's Richmond Field Office, dated January 23, 2023. The Bureau was monitoring Traditional Catholic parishes, alleging ties between "racially or ethnically motivated violent extremists" and "radical-traditionalist Catholic" beliefs—code, the memo implied, for SSPX adherents. The framing suggested these groups posed a potential threat going into the 2024 election.

The specifics were familiar to me in a way that made my stomach turn. In Richmond, the FBI had zeroed in on an SSPX parishioner who posted online rants

under the name "Radical Traditional Catholic Clerical Fascist." He had been arrested with an arsenal—eight Molotov cocktails, six smoke bombs, a smoke grenade, firearms, and ammunition—after posting anti-Zionist and anti-progressive content. In Portland, the FBI had investigated Robert Reynolds, a deceased SSPX attendee suspected of vandalism and white supremacist activity, who had captioned a photo at an SSPX parish: "The Holy Sacrifice of the Mass. Join the Catholic Taliban." In Los Angeles, another SSPX parishioner, allegedly a member of the neo-Nazi group Legio Christi, had been caught attempting to acquire unregistered firearms.

I sat back on my heels on the bathroom tiles. My suspicions were confirmed. This was not about persecuting Catholics who cherished the solemnity of the Latin Mass. It was about the SSPX—a world I knew too well, where piety could mask militancy. The chaos in Richmond felt tied to the fractures in my own family—to my father's conspiracies, to my siblings' estrangement, to my mother's dying pleas.

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Conservatives on social media were calling the FBI's actions naked aggression, the Biden administration weaponizing the DOJ. They pointed to the raid on Mark Houck.

On September 23, 2022, at 6:45 a.m., Houck had been making coffee and checking the news while his wife and seven children slept. The quiet was shattered by pounding on the door and shouts of "Open up!" Twenty-five FBI agents, some with M-16s drawn, surrounded his home with fifteen vehicles lining the street. Houck was the founder of The King's Men, a Catholic pro-life group that offered sidewalk counseling at abortion clinics. He was being charged under the FACE Act for an incident in October 2021 in which he had pushed a Planned Parenthood escort to the ground after the escort had verbally harassed Houck's twelve-year-old son. Local authorities had declined to prosecute. A private criminal complaint had been dismissed. The U.S. Attorney

pursued it anyway. Houck was handcuffed in shorts and flip-flops in front of his wife and children and taken away. The lead agent, when asked why they were there, replied, "You know why." Houck retorted, "If Trump were in the White House, you wouldn't be here." Houck was acquitted on January 30, 2023.

The notion that this was overreach was not as far-fetched as it sounded. Thirty years earlier, U.S. Marshals had descended on Randy Weaver's cabin in the Idaho mountains after Weaver failed to appear in court for selling two sawed-off shotguns to an undercover ATF agent. The Marshals, on covert surveillance, were spotted by Weaver's dog, Striker. A Marshal shot the dog. Weaver's fourteen-year-old son Sammy fired toward the sound and was killed by a Marshal's bullet. A firefight erupted. Weaver's friend Kevin Harris killed one of the Marshals. An eleven-day standoff followed. An FBI sniper later shot and killed Weaver's wife Vicki as she stood in the doorway of the cabin holding their baby.

The Ruby Ridge standoff drew national attention and drew far-right groups—including Neo-Nazis from the Aryan Nations compound at Hayden Lake—to the road outside the cabin to protest government overreach.

For my father, Ruby Ridge marked the birth of the American militia movement. I first heard about it shortly after my high school graduation, around the same time tensions were flaring in St. Mary's, Kansas. It was also when I first heard the term New World Order.

To people like my father, Ruby Ridge was a signal. The government would come next for a family like ours—homeschoolers, traditionalist Catholics, people who had withdrawn from a world they saw as corrupt. The Weavers had removed themselves to the Idaho mountains to shield their children. I witnessed so many families move to St.

Marys, Kansas, driven by the same fears. They were so fearful, they just wanted to save their souls and the souls of their children.

Ruby Ridge was the first domino. Waco followed. Then the Montana Freeman. The Kansas Freeman. The Republic of Texas. And worst of all, Oklahoma City. Few knew how those events intersected in St. Mary's, Kansas, or how they connected to what Traditional Catholics would have called a centuries-old battle of good and evil. They saw Ruby Ridge as a symptom of the prophecy of Fatima — Russia spreading her errors. Randy Weaver was one of the ones trying to shield his children from those errors. To many Traditional Catholics, it was a clash of worldviews: those who believed in a God active in human affairs versus those who denied any role for God in history. That belief fueled their rejection of modern Catholicism.

The events at Ruby Ridge and Waco echoed from the past, their concern had been renewed by the "stolen" election, and now the FBI was allegedly monitoring Traditional Catholics in Richmond. To some, it was proof of a creeping New World Order. For them—for my mother—it was enough to be convinced they had to take a stand.

None of it came as a shock to me. I remembered the comforting feeling of moral superiority that came from the belief we were part of the elect ordained by God to a final crusade. I remembered the initiation, the epiphany, of new members drinking the SSPX Kool-Aid. I remembered Bishop Williamson railing from the pulpit against Vatican II—a Masonic-Zionist-Communist plot, Sunday after Sunday. "Salvation is found in attending the TRUE Mass!" he would thunder. "The LATIN Mass is the TRUE Mass!" I remembered mild, pious folks being transformed into wild-eyed fanatics by that bitter zeal. Once someone was radicalized, it became nearly impossible to reason with them. If it were not for the pains I had suffered, I might never have broken free. I had always wanted to justify it, rationalize it, make excuses for it.

The spirit of division and its attending zeal was alive and well in 2023. It took many forms: on the right, radical traditional Catholics call for the end of women's suffrage; on the left, gender ideologues call for the end of a rational understanding of human gender—each side fueled by narratives like the stolen election or George Floyd's death. Each side demonized the other, on a steady diet of outrage.

Many on the right were piling into the bandwagon based on Seraphin's claims about the FBI. But I had grown up hearing conspiracy theories—Pope Paul VI was a Freemason, the Church was infiltrated by the KGB, the Vatican is full of Satanists. I had come to know that these matters required serious investigation which required time, resources, and resolve to not lose sight of objectivity—an attribute that is becoming less and less common.

I was not a Biden fan. But I was compelled to doubt that the FBI was targeting Catholics simply for their faith. I had lived long enough to see how often the truth gets distorted in conflict, and how common it is for the truth to be bent for particular gain. I also knew how hard it is to accept the truth when it is staring you in the face. In 1993, I had not wanted to believe my tribe was capable of the things I was being told about it. But it had been true. Seraphin and the conservative pundits did not know what I knew. This was not just about the Latin Mass. It was not just about the left versus the right, or good versus evil. It was not an either-or. It was a both-and. We were all, to some degree, to blame.

The truth, I would soon learn, was stranger than fiction.

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"Dahhhhdeeee, coooold!" Betty yelled from the tub.

I came out of it. I grabbed a towel and lifted her and her brother out, bundled them, carried them downstairs for pajamas.

Allison caught the look on my face. "Everything okay, babe?"

"Yeah," I said.

"What's up?"

"Just a little déjà vu."

Chapter 2

Gens, Gentis

All parents damage their children. It cannot be helped. Youth, like pristine glass, absorbs the prints of its handlers. — Mitch Albom

March 1945

Eastwood, New York

The red neon "Open" sign at Guilfoil's Irish Pub in the quiet Eastwood neighborhood of East Syracuse pulsed like a heartbeat against the night sky, its crimson glow fractured by sheets of rain that battered the window of the cramped room above the bar. The light bled into the darkness, scattering sparks across the glass, as if the storm itself were alight with some restless energy. Inside, Petey lay beside his mother on a sagging mattress, the air thick with the scent of damp wool and stale cigarette smoke that clung to her apron. The neon's flicker cast fleeting shadows across her face, sharpening the lines of worry etched there, remnants of the fiery words that had erupted between her and his father hours earlier. Money, always money — their voices had clashed like iron on iron, each accusation sparking embers that Petey could still feel smoldering in his chest.

The Second World War had ended, its distant roar silenced, and the world outside rejoiced in a fragile peace. But in the Massett home on Shafer Avenue in Lyncourt, New York, peace was a stranger. The walls of their narrow house seemed to hold their breath, braced for the next outburst. That night, Peter and his mother had fled to the pub's upstairs room, a sanctuary of sorts, though its peeling wallpaper and creaking floorboards offered little comfort. As the youngest of four, Peter was no stranger to the undercurrents of tension that swirled through their home, a current as relentless as the rain outside. His mother, Agnes D'Arcy Massett, had returned to work

as a waitress at Guilfoil's now that Peter was old enough to be left untended. In the 1940s, a married woman with a gainfully employed husband stepping into the workforce was an act of defiance, a breach of unspoken rules. But Agnes was no ordinary woman. She carried the fierce spirit of her Irish ancestors, her will as unyielding as the cliffs of her native Liverpool. At eighteen, she had crossed an ocean to chase a dream in America, leaving behind the familiar weight of family and tradition. Peter's father, Raymond Massett, was cut from different cloth—German immigrant stock, raised on a farm where frugality was a virtue and simplicity a creed. Their visions of happiness were as irreconcilable as stone and sea, each refusing to yield, their stubbornness a shared inheritance that bound them even as it tore them apart.

"Petey," his mother's voice broke the silence, soft but urgent, "if I leave your father, you'll come with me, won't you?"

He didn't answer. His eyes traced the neon sparks outside, each one a fleeting flare against the dark, like the fleeting hope he harbored that his family might hold together. The rain drummed a restless rhythm on the roof, mirroring the unease in his heart.

"James said he'd come with me," she pressed, her British accent curling around the words like smoke. "Won't you, Petey?"

"No," he said at last, the word heavy as stone. "I'm staying with Pa."

It wasn't true, not entirely. At five years old, he didn't want to choose his father over his mother. What he wanted was impossible: for the shouting to stop, for the sparks of their anger to cool, for the family to remain whole. He believed, with the desperate logic of a child, that refusing her might anchor her to them, might keep her from leaving.

He was right. His parents never separated. But that moment, with its weight of unspoken choices, carved itself into my father's young soul, shaping how he faced conflict and loss, how he carried the weight of family through the years. This is how I imagine these events unfolded, based on the snippets of conversation with my father and fleeting mentions from my mother—each one a shard of glass reflecting a past I could never fully grasp. The significance of this event would go on to have a profound impact on me and many of my siblings, as if we were all captive in some way or another to the psyche of a 5-year-old boy who feared his parents might divorce. This was, after all, the first serious fight my father would win in life. It explained why ostracization was his "go-to" when people did not bend to his will.

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Fighting was the hallmark of his life. Growing up, my father often spoke of why he never wanted my mother to work. The chaos of his childhood, he said, was a wound he didn't want us to bear. His parents' fights were not mere arguments, but tempests—their voices crashing like waves against rock. They never raised their hands to each other, but their words were weapons, sharp and unrelenting.

He told me how as a boy he'd lie awake at night, his stomach knotting as their voices rose and fell through the thin walls. The sound was a physical thing, a pressure in his chest, a reminder that love could be as brutal as it was binding. He hated arguing, he said, because it reminded him of those nights. Better to use his fists, he'd say, than let words fester. And use them he did.

His older brother Ray was a storm of his own, picking fights with their sister Irene and brother James—whom everyone called Duke—until the violence cascaded downward, landing on Tommy. The beatings were a hierarchy, a brutal order among

siblings. Irene, desperate for escape, would often lock herself in the bathroom, the click of the bolt her only defense against the chaos.

My father and his brothers were like characters from S.E. Hinton's *The Outsiders*, forged in the rough crucible of Lyncourt's streets. Toughness was their currency, earned through scraped knuckles and unyielding pride. When they weren't fighting each other, they followed their cousin Cliff Hart into boxing, the ring where their anger found form.

I learned of my father's penchant for getting into "scraps," on a weekend trip to the Adirondacks with my Uncle Ray. His voice rolled like thunder as he recounted tales of their brawls, his eyes gleaming with the thrill of memory. Even at seven, I could feel the pull of his stories, the way they wove violence into valor.

"Looper," he said, a nickname bestowed upon me by my grandfather, his baritone slow and deliberate, like a man reciting a legend, "your dad and Uncle Duke were a force to be reckoned with.

"Did you ever hear about the time a guy called your Uncle Duke a Polak?" he asked, leaning closer, the campfire casting shadows across his weathered face.

I shook my head, captivated.

"Your old man and Uncle Duke just came back to town from a talk on whitetail deer hunting," he began, "and stopped at a gin mill for a drink. A guy at the bar noticed your Uncle Duke's name tag—he'd forgotten to take it off—and started in:

"Hey, Polak! Don't you know your own name?"

"The loudmouth then said, 'Look, this Polak doesn't even know his own name! Hey, Jim, you a dumb Polak?'

"Duke says to the guy, 'Are we going to have a problem?'

"'You tell me, Polak,' the guy laughed, and stood up. He was big, six-foot-two, 230 pounds at least.

"'You wanna go outside, Polak?' the guy says. So your Uncle Duke finished his beer, stood, and said, 'Let's go.'

"Outside, the man smirked, and offered Duke the first punch. 'Since you're so scrawny,' he said. Duke didn't hesitate, WHAP! His right cross landed smack dab on the guy's temple, dropping like a sack of potatoes."

Ray's laughter echoed as he told the story, the sound rich with pride. He told many stories of fist fights they got into.

As a child, I felt a surge of awe, my blood thrumming with the knowledge that my family was forged in fire. But when I returned home later that weekend, I asked my father about his own bar fights, hoping to find a common connection. "Uncle Ray told me you once knocked somebody out." I said. My father's voice carried a different weight. "Well, it isn't something I'm too proud of." He said, "I thought I'd killed him," he went on, his eyes distant, fixed on some unseen horizon. "After I knocked him out, he lay half on Route 31, motionless, someone had to drag him off the road. For thirty minutes, I waited, I was afraid I might go to jail for manslaughter. I went to St. Francis's Church and prayed. When we drove by the bar, he was gone. "

The contrast between my Uncle's attitude towards conflict and my father's struck me like a blow. Ray reveled in the chaos, while my father weighed its cost. It was a glimpse into the fault lines of their youth, where violence was both shield and scar. The difference was marked by father's "reversion" to his faith. He saw his former violence as a sin, where my Uncle saw it as a conquest. But the fighting spirit that

robbed my father of peace in his childhood would serve to rob him of peace his entire life. It ultimately led to a rift between him and my Uncle over a Union dispute. It would drive a wedge between him and his sister over the Church. Rather than seek reconciliation over their differences my father treated those who opposed him in the way he treated his mother. I believe that experience misled him to believe this was the best way to "bend" people to your will.

While my father and his siblings were all raised Catholic, none of them had much faith formation growing up. They were like most kids of their generation—cultural Catholics. The only thing that mattered was Mass attendance. My father's childhood was split between two worlds: the city, which was a crucible—fast, aggressive, its streets alive with the hum of danger—and the Adirondacks, by contrast, which was a sanctuary, their vast silences broken only by the rustle of leaves and the snap of twigs. My grandfather, Ninapa—"Pa" to us—was the bridge between these worlds. A true outdoorsman, he was indifferent to the sport of boxing that consumed his sons, allowed them to own the streets. He'd watch fights on the flickering screen of their old television, but his heart was in the earth. Each summer, he coaxed life from the soil in his garden. He'd go fishing every day. Each fall, he led his sons into the mountains to hunt and fish. His love for the Adirondacks was contagious, spreading to his nephews, a sprawling clan bound by blood and the shared rhythm of the hunt.

Every Friday in Autumn after work, Pa would take my father and uncles on a drive two hours from Eastwood up to the Moose River in the Adirondack Mountains where they'd hike five miles deep into the woods to their "camp" they had set up during the summer months. Their "camp" was nothing more than a tent, a makeshift stove, and 50 gallon barrels where they stored their supplies. They'd arrive late Friday night and hunt through the weekend. Pa's dedication to the art of hunting was matched only by his religious convictions. What set him apart from the rest of his family was his faith.

Every Sunday morning at 5am, no matter the weather—rain, snow, or biting cold—he hiked out at dawn, his boys trailing behind, to attend Mass in the nearby town. Then after Mass they'd trek 5 miles back, the day's hunt resuming under his steady gaze.

His nephews, less devout, chose not to go to Mass, as their father was more concerned about the lost hunting time. "Why waste the morning?" he'd mutter when Pa was out of earshot.

At seventeen, my father lacked his Pa's steadfastness. One weekend, he went with his cousins to hunt at a different location from my grandfather. He drank too much, the whiskey blurring the edges of his resolve. "C'mon, Peter," his cousins teased, "missing one Mass won't kill you." For the first time, he chose not to hike out for Mass, the weight of his choice settling like ash.

That night, Pa's voice was quiet but firm. "Why weren't you at Mass?"

"What's the big deal? " my father asked flippantly.

In a flash, Pa's hand cracked across his face, the sound sharp as a rifle shot. "You don't ever miss Mass," he thundered, his usual softness replaced by iron.

My father stood stunned, his cheek burning, his pride a raw wound. That slap drove him to rebellion. Later that week, my father and his cousin Les pooled \$100, packed their rifles and leather jackets into Les's Mustang, and set out for California, leaving only the dust of their departure—with no intention to return.

They figured they could save money by hunting as they went along—living off the land like true adventurers, hunting for food, cooking by campfire. But in Nebraska, under a sky vast and indifferent, a thief stole their money and guns, leaving them stranded. They tried to find work in the nearby town, but no one was interested in

hiring hoodlums from out of town. Within a matter of 48 hours, the dire reality of their situation set in. Hunger gnawed at them, reducing them to scavenging roadkill. That night as they lay out under the starry sky, his stomach rumbling with hunger, my father's head cleared. He couldn't help but shake the feeling that God was trying to prove a point. All his life he heard at CCD how important it was for Catholics to receive Communion because it "fed the soul"—it was spiritual nourishment. Now that he was starving for the first time in his life, he understood why his father slapped him. "What good does it profit a man to gain the whole world if he loses his immortal soul?" Staring up at the sky, he admitted the real reason he left New York was not because his father did him wrong, but because he did wrong skipping Mass, missing out on that spiritual food. God was showing him that without Providence in your life, you will starve. The next morning they called their Aunt Helen, who sent money on one condition: they return home.

This event was one of many that would shape my father's and our lives. This experience galvanized in his psyche just how important the Mass was for Roman Catholics. And he would fight for it. He never spoke of that slap except to my mother. He saw his misfortunes in Nebraska as a sign from God the Father that he was not meant to leave New York and that he deserved the slap from Pa—he was in the wrong. She shared the story when I was a teenager, her voice soft with understanding. It explained why my father asked every Sunday, "Where'd you go to Mass today?" The Mass, for him, was a tether, a way to hold fast against the chaos of his youth.

My mother, who was gifted at understanding people and had grown up starved for attention, learned quickly that smoothing his edges was the price of peace. The family on her side saw it. They said, not always kindly, that he walked all over her.

Once, though—only once that I ever heard her describe—she pushed back. My father had been out late with his pals, drinking at a gin mill, and had broken his promise to come home at a specific hour. My mother and a friend drove to the bar, sneaked up to where the motorcycles were parked outside, and hid them. They sat in their car across the street and watched, stifling laughter, as my father and his friends stumbled out into the lot looking for transportation that had vanished. When she told me this story, decades later, she was grinning. It was the only time I ever saw that grin. It was the grin of a person who had once, for one night, been allowed to be a person.

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By 1965 she had been pregnant continuously for most of five years. She wanted to stop. My father, in quiet confession, went to their pastor Fr. Dunn, and said so. Fr. Dunn had been the one who warned them that their marriage would not last. Now Fr. Dunn said something different: "It's okay. The word is that the Vatican is soon going to reverse its position on contraception." The ground under my father's feet shifted. How could the eternal stake of damnation become a timing question? He and my mother cherished Fr. Dunn, and Fr. Dunn was telling him to go ahead. Reluctantly, he yielded. My mother got the pill.

For three years the family rested at five children.

Then, in 1968, Pope Paul VI published *Humanae Vitae* and reaffirmed the ban. The Church had not been, as Fr. Dunn had let them believe, about to lift it. My father had been misled. The absolution he had trusted had evaporated underneath him. He and my mother had been living, according to the Church's restated position, in a state of mortal sin for three straight years, every day, every month, at Fr. Dunn's own suggestion.

They did not stop. They had tasted relief. For the first time in their marriage my mother had had three years of knowing her own body was hers. Many Catholics that year stopped listening to Rome. Some stopped being Catholic. My father, for his part, tucked the betrayal deep into his chest and carried it forward. He would use it later to justify turning against bishops and popes when they failed him again. The fault line was drawn. The earthquake hadn't yet hit.

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The five of them—Peter Jr., Joan, Donna, Jarred and Lisa—grew up through the late 1960s inside what became, against every prediction, a functioning home. My father took up amateur photography. Evenings filled with the clatter of a 9mm film projector throwing pictures of picnics and birthdays up onto the living-room wall. My parents, for all their cracks, had managed to weave something their own childhoods had not given them: a tapestry of ordinary American Catholic stability.

Then, in the spring of 1970, my grandmother—Nina, Ninapa's wife, the woman who had once brokered the fragile peace between my parents—was diagnosed with pancreatic cancer. The surgeons opened her up and found the tumor wrapped around her aorta. They could not cut it out without killing her. They closed her back up and gave her a handful of months.

My father had lost his mother once, at five years old, in the upstairs room of an Irish pub. He was not going to lose her again.

He went looking for a miracle. And the miracle, when it came, would come through a blind Italian-American produce man named Joey Lomangino, who had driven a van up from Long Island to stand on a pine hillside in Garabandal, Spain, to wait for the Virgin Mary to return his sight. Which is where the next chapter begins, and where my family—though none of us yet knew it—was about to be remade.

Chapter 3

The Wheel in the Sky

A great sign appeared in heaven: a woman clothed with the sun, with the moon under her feet and a crown of twelve stars on her head. —Revelation 12:1

May 1970

Bridgeport, New York

My father lost his welding job in Utica the same month my grandmother got her death sentence. A lunch-break remark of his—half-idle, about how few Utica men had taken the prize overtime on the project—got carried back to the union in a warped version, as if he were urging Utica men to walk off other jobs for this one. Two days later he and two other Syracuse men were handed pink slips for a thing he had never said. He came home furious. The next morning the Syracuse local called with a different offer: would he foreman a job rebuilding Holy Cross Church in DeWitt? He took it before the man finished the sentence.

Holy Cross had a daily noon Mass. Every day that summer, with my grandmother Nina dying in a hospital bed across town, he knelt in the pews during his lunch hour and asked God to spare her. Through the parish prayer group he met a woman named Jane Pigott, and one evening Jane mentioned a pilgrimage she was helping organize to Garabandal in northern Spain, where the Blessed Mother had recently been reported to appear to four village children. My grandmother had already pressed a worn paperback on the Garabandal apparitions into my father's hands the week before. He asked Jane if there was any way he could go. The spots were full. Two weeks later Jane called him back: a pilgrim had dropped out, and the spot had come free—paid. He didn't argue with providence.

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The man sitting next to my father on the bus winding through the Cantabrian mountains toward the village was a blind Italian-American produce wholesaler from Long Island named Joey Lomangino. He was the reason they were going, in a sense — one of the early American champions of the Garabandal apparitions. That day he was just a stranger in the next seat telling my father the story of his life, and my father was listening the way men listen in the middle of a crisis, which is to say, with everything.

Joey had been eighteen years old when the tire he was inflating in his father's garage blew up in his face. The blast took his sight and his sense of smell in a single instant. He told my father about his first weeks at the school for the blind — stumbling down a stairwell at night trying to find the bathroom, being carried back to his bed by attendants, weeping himself to sleep. That night he dreamed of a natural amphitheater made of pine trees, and in the amphitheater he saw the Blessed Mother, and she told him he would one day see again. He woke up and kept the dream like a piece of paper folded in a pocket for years, even as his faith wore down. By his early thirties his health was failing from overwork. His doctor told him to take time off. His Italian parents sent him to visit family in the old country, where a pious aunt pressed him to visit a monastery at San Giovanni Rotondo to meet a priest named Padre Pio.

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Joey went as a skeptic. He stood at the back of the vestibule after Padre Pio celebrated Mass, listening to the crowd press forward for blessings, guarding his heart. Padre Pio came through the doorway, paused, and without seeing Joey he called his name, blessed him, and touched his cheek.

Joey's uncle who was with him swore he had told no one they were coming. Joey, shaken, asked him again. Nobody had told Padre Pio. Nobody could have.

Joey's encounter with Padre Pio stirred something in his soul. So much so that he returned two years later and stood in the confession line for hours—Padre Pio was famous for hearing confession until he could no longer hold his head up—and when he finally sat down across from the priest, he rattled off that he was surprised it was face to face. Padre Pio grabbed him by the wrist and said in English, "Joey, confess yourself."

"Bless me, Father, for I have sinned..." But the priest interrupted him. "Joey, you're angry, eh?" - "No, Father, I work hard, I'm tired..." - "No, No, Joey, you're angry, eh?" As Joey searched for words to begin, Padre Pio started to tell him his sins—in English. Joey recalls, "It went like this: this *Italian* priest began, 'Joey, do you recall one night in a bar, a girl named Barbara, the sin you committed.' I said, 'Yes, Padre, I do, and then he went right down the list in English: the dates, the names, the sins I committed, and the places I was at. I was one piece of water. After he was all through he said, 'Joey, are you sorry?' I answered 'Yes, Father, I am.' Then Padre Pio raised his hand in the air and said, 'I call Jesus and Mary for you.' I said, 'For me? You call Jesus and Mary for me?' He said, 'Si.' As Padre Pio gave me absolution, my eyes began to roll in my head. I started to rub my face, my head kept going around and around. I felt something was happening to me but I didn't know what it was. All of a sudden my head cleared. Then Padre Pio touched my lips, made me kiss the wound on his hand, gave a tap on the face, and said, 'Joey, a little patience, a little courage and you're going to be all right.'"

At the end, penitent and shaking, Joey asked if Padre Pio could restore his sight.

"I'll give you what I can," the priest said. "Wait for me after Mass in the vestibule."

After Mass, Joey pushed to the front of the crowd, his uncle calling out that Padre Pio had summoned him. When the priest reached him he made the sign of the cross over Joey's forehead and laid his hand there. A searing pain shot through Joey's sinuses. He recoiled. And then, for the first time in thirteen years, he smelled roses.

"It may not seem like much to you," Joey told my father, "but to smell again was a gift beyond words."

It was also a medical impossibility. Doctors had confirmed that the blast severed his olfactory nerve. Joey didn't get his sight back that day. He got his smell back, and he got his faith back, which he said was harder to explain and bigger than any of it.

Later, he asked the priest about the Marian apparitions being reported across Europe. Padre Pio told him most of them were nothing. But one of them—he said a town's name in Spain my father had never heard—was real. "She is in Garabandal. Go there."

Joey flew to Spain. When the village guide led him up the hill to the apparition site and described the topography—a natural semicircle of pine trees above the village—Joey began to cry, and my father, telling me this story thirty years later on a drive home from a funeral, said he had never before heard a grown man cry the way Joey cried on that hillside. It was the amphitheater from the dream at the school for the blind. He was finally standing inside the piece of paper he had carried folded in his pocket.

Joey did not get his sight back at Garabandal either. He got something else. He told my father he had gone up the hill asking for his eyes, and what the Blessed Mother had given him instead was a way to see that did not need them. From that day on he became Garabandal's loudest American defender. It was the work he did for the rest of his life.

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My father listened to all of this with his hands on his knees. He had boarded that bus looking for a cure for my grandmother. He was starting to realize he had been handed something else, and he did not yet know what to do with it.

What the Virgin had reportedly said to the Garabandal children cut into him hardest. "Many cardinals, bishops, and priests are on the path to perdition, and they are dragging countless souls with them." Those were not words he was prepared to receive from heaven. But they matched, almost too well, the uneasy thing he had been carrying since Fr. Dunn told him in 1965 that the Vatican was about to reverse its teaching on contraception, and then *Humanae Vitae* had revealed Fr. Dunn had been wrong, and my father had been living in what the Church now said was mortal sin because a priest had told him it was fine. The Virgin's warning at Garabandal didn't feel abstract. It felt like somebody had finally put the word on the thing.

He began to catalogue other cracks. A newly ordained priest at his parish, Father Weitz, sitting on the church steps with a cigarette, looking like a man who had lost something. Father Weitz would leave the priesthood within the year. His oldest son Pete's First Communion in 1967 had required Confession first; his daughter Joan's First Communion the next year had not, because the rule had quietly changed. Small inconsistencies, each of which had struck my father as odd at the time and been set aside. In the language of Garabandal, they were no longer odd. They were symptoms.

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My father, like so many pioneers in the Traditional Catholic movement, had been raised on Fatima the way some American Catholic boys are raised on baseball. In 1917, three shepherd children in Portugal had reported seeing the Virgin six times in a field outside the village of Fatima. Threatened with prison, with death, they had held their story. The Virgin had promised a sign, and on October 13 of that year seventy thousand people—peasants, skeptics, and a secular journalist—had gathered in the rain. The clouds broke. Witnesses said the sun spun in the sky for fifteen minutes and then appeared to plunge toward the earth. The crowd screamed. When it was over, the sodden muddy field was dry.

The Fatima seers had reported three "secrets." The first was a vision of hell. The second foretold the rise of "the errors of Russia" and the Second World War. The third—meant to be revealed by the Pope in 1960—was withheld, and the withholding became a whole Catholic cottage industry of speculation. By 1970 a thin consensus had formed among conservative Catholics, fanned by Archbishop Fulton Sheen on his prime-time television show, that the third secret foretold a crisis of faith inside the Church itself. That interpretation had seemed unthinkable to most American Catholics a decade before, when the pews and seminaries had still been full. But some of the faithful in the wake of Vatican II—most notably a French archbishop named Marcel Lefebvre—had begun to feel it in their bones.

My father had never heard of Marcel Lefebvre. He would, in time.

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He flew home from Spain in August 1970 carrying a miracle he had not come for. My grandmother was not going to get her life back. He understood that now. But his faith had come back like a thing he had been trying to recover, and it set her on fire too. In the eight months Nina had left, she made peace with Ninapa, made peace with her own childhood, made peace with God. She died in April 1971. My father built a life-sized cross in the backyard with his own hands, and planted a garden around it. A month after Nina's funeral my mother gave birth to my sister Marie. My father, with no hesitation, asked Joey Lomangino and Jane Pigott to be her godparents.

Those were the circumstances that changed the trajectory of my family. It was not a theological decision. It was a grief that needed somewhere to go, and a blind man on a bus in Spain, and a priest in Italy who was a miracle worker. My father came home a different man, and the rest of us—the ones already born, and the ones yet to be born—were going to be raised inside the shape of the difference.

Chapter 4

Shangri-La

The love of a family is life's greatest blessing. —Eva Burrows

January 22nd, 1973

Syracuse, New York

I was born on January 22, 1973, which happens to be the day the United States Supreme Court decided *Roe v. Wade*. My father, by this point two and a half years into his new life as a Marian foot soldier and already a founding member of Jane Pigott's Syracuse Right to Life chapter, did not consider this a coincidence. "There are no coincidences, Louie," he would say for the rest of his life, whenever I pointed out any of the other ones. My father named me Louis Grignion after St. Louis de Montfort, the French apostle of Marian devotion whose full name was Louis-Marie Grignion de Montfort. He wanted me to be a priest. He assumed, with the happy certainty of a convert, that heaven had simply signed my paperwork the same morning America had signed the other thing, and that the scoreboard was even.

I was born with a small hole in my heart. I came home from the hospital during a central New York snowstorm—gray sky, five inches of new snow, wind chill well below zero—wrapped in blankets in my mother's arms. The pediatrician had warned that a simple cold could be serious. Sister Catherine, who taught sixth-grade religion at the parish school, had told my sister Joan, age eleven, that unbaptized infants could not enter heaven. Joan, who was already my father's daughter in temperament—decisive, unafraid, convinced of her own authority—overheard my parents at the dinner table talking about my lungs, excused herself, found a vial of holy water, slipped into the nursery, and baptized me herself.

"I baptize you," she whispered over me, "in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Spirit."

The following Sunday, dressing the kids for Mass, my mother said something about my upcoming baptism. Joan shrugged.

"Oh, I already did that."

"You what?"

"I was afraid he might die."

They scolded her. They also, privately, kept the vial. The priest did the official sacrament later that day. But Joan's was the one I was actually baptized with, and she was, as my father liked to say, "not taking any chances with your soul" — which would turn out to be the house disposition toward me for most of my childhood.

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The world I came into was, from my vantage point, perfect. My grandparents had years earlier bought a long stretch of shoreline on Oneida Lake and dreamed that their grown children would build homes on it. My Aunt Irene and her husband Sam built a house with an in-law suite on the first floor for my grandparents; my father built our house next door; Uncle Duke and Aunt Ruth built a mile down the road. After Nina died, Ninapa moved into the in-law suite at Irene's, and within a year or two he had remarried a widow named Grace Weichert, whom he had met in Florida. That was the family compound. It was the entire horizon of my early life.

One of my first clear memories is standing in my crib after naptime while my five older siblings fought over who I wanted to lift me out. Pete was 13, Joan 12, Donna 11, Jarred 10, and Lisa 8. I was two. They were titans to me, and I adored them. I was the seventh — "lucky number seven," my father called me — and the 1970s rock they played

in the house from their bedrooms, electric guitars and pounded drums, was the soundtrack of my worship of them.

The adults who made up the rest of the compound were part of the same warmth. Every morning at dawn I would put on a T-shirt and swim trunks and run barefoot across the wet grass to Ninapa and Grace's suite next door. If I timed it right, I caught them between Ninapa's morning fishing and his morning gardening, and they would feed me Rice Krispies with sliced banana. They called me Mr. Why-Why because I asked too many questions, and Ninapa, who was otherwise a man of few words, indulged all of them, except when we were on the lake trying to fish and my talking scared the fish. If Ninapa was already on the water by the time I arrived, I went to Aunt Irene next, who kept Apple Jacks in the pantry because she knew I was coming, and would go fishing herself at a later hour.

I had an imagination that outran my comprehension of the world. At three or four I burst into my mother's bedroom one morning screaming "The pirates are coming!" She looked out the window and saw what I had seen—a regatta of Saturday-morning sailboats beating across the lake toward Cicero—and laughed and told me that's not what pirates look like. To me, everything was epic, every moment pulsing with possibility. That zest for life, that unbridled optimism, defined me—sometimes to a fault, landing me in trouble.

Because of the hole in my heart, my parents, especially my mother, had been afraid from day one that crying might tax me, and so they disciplined me sparingly. They later admitted this openly: I was spoiled. My mother called my sister Marie "the sun," for how easy she was, and me "the clouds." Bedtime was my endless theater of rebellion—I couldn't understand why the older kids got to stay up and watch television with my parents and I didn't, and most nights I'd tiptoe out to the living room like a tiny spy, get caught and sent back, then five minutes later try again, until my father finally delivered

the swat that meant it for real. My only real childhood conflict, in those Shangri-La years, was my refusal to be separated from the rest of them even by a hallway and a bedtime.

• • •

I yearned to preserve my world in a perfect, unchanging bubble, and I'd hurl myself into battle to defend it, heedless of the fallout. I rarely paused to consider how my actions rippled through those around me.

One vivid memory crystallizes this: I was three when my mother joined Weight Watchers. The morning of her first meeting, she announced she was leaving me with my older siblings. The words landed like a thunderbolt, shattering my sense of security. Betrayal seared my heart—this was the first time I recall her stepping out of my orbit. I raced to the window, my small hands pressed against the cool glass, watching her car vanish down the street. Tears streamed down my cheeks, a torrent of grief and confusion. *Will she return? Why is she leaving me?* My tiny soul was a storm of despair and fury.

The next week, the scene repeated like a cruel rerun. She declared her departure, and I unraveled, sprinting to the window to witness her car's taillights fade. My sobs echoed through the house, a keening wail of abandonment.

By the third week, I resolved to act. As she prepared for her "weigh-in," I spotted a pair of scissors glinting on the table. With the fierce logic of a toddler, I snipped every strap on her shoes, certain that broken footwear would tether her to me. In my mind it was a master plan. Instead, it earned me a stinging spanking that left my backside throbbing, a vivid lesson in consequences. To my dismay she left anyway, her resolve unshaken.

Week four brought a torturous crossroads. She was leaving again, and the thought pierced me like a shard of glass. My heart screamed to fight, but the memory of that fiery spanking lingered, a cautionary blaze. Yet surrender was unthinkable. I couldn't bear another parting. Then, inspiration struck—a memory of my mother's horrified shriek weeks earlier: "Louie, stop bringing those slimy earthworms inside!"

That was it. My wriggling allies from beneath the flagstone path became my secret weapon. If I slipped a few into her shoes, her revulsion would surely keep her home. I carefully tucked them into the toes of her flats, smug with my cunning. But my plan backfired spectacularly. She discovered the worms, and the spanking that followed was a whirlwind of maternal wrath, leaving me smarting and stunned.

By the fifth week, the dread of her absence weighed like a stone in my chest. I overheard her on the phone, recounting the worm fiasco to friends with a mix of exasperation and amusement. "Those disgusting worms," she'd say, "I could barely touch my shoes!" I was so close to breaking her Weight Watchers spell, I could feel it. In a desperate bid, I decided to amplify the horror. Before her next meeting, I took those worms, grimly fed them through a pencil sharpener, and smeared the gruesome remains into her shoes. In my frantic toddler logic, this grotesque display would finally convince her to stay. I pictured her recoiling, vowing never to leave again.

Instead, her scream—"Loooooooooooouuuuuiiiiiieeeeeeee!"—pierced the air like a siren. I fled, heart pounding, but there was no escape. The spanking that ensued was a masterpiece of parental fury, leaving me chastened and sore. Weight Watchers emerged victorious, and I was left licking my wounds. (For the record, that was my sole act of cruelty to any creature.)

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Of all of my older siblings, Donna was the warmest. Joan was bookish and already pulling away — we didn't know yet that an aneurysm was forming in her brain, quietly editing her temper — and Lisa was Lisa, too old to really bother with me. But Donna was a second mother. I would creep into the bedroom she shared with her sisters at night when the house had gone dark and nightmares came for me, and I would slide into her bed, and she would let me stay. That routine held until the night of the chicks.

Donna brought home three yellow chicks from a science project at school. She had hatched them herself. I named them Huey, Louie, and Dewy, after the nephews in *Donald Duck*. Donna set them up in a cardboard box on the kitchen floor under a heat lamp. That night I could not sleep. I kept thinking about the chicks. I crept downstairs in my bare feet, the wooden stairs cold, and I poured myself a glass of Welch's grape juice at the counter. Standing by the wood stove where Donna had put the box, I drank it and watched the chicks huddle together under the lamp. They looked, to me, exactly as cold as I was. The lamp was plainly not enough.

I fetched a plastic mixing bowl from the cupboard. I scooped all three chicks into it gently, the way I had seen Donna do. I carried the bowl up the stairs to Donna's room and set the chicks between us on the bed. Donna had her back to us. I petted the tops of their soft heads and told them they were safe now, and fell asleep smiling.

I woke to Donna screaming my name.

"Louieeeeeee!"

The chicks were dead. All three of them. I had rolled onto them in the night.

Donna was crying. My mother came in and saw the bowl, and the look on her face was the first time in my life I understood that an adult I loved was disappointed in me in a way I could not talk her out of. Donna could not even look at me. I had not meant to do it. I had been trying to save them from the cold, dark night.

I have thought about this scene more times than it probably deserves. Everything I am going to spend the rest of this book describing—the ideology, the convictions, the crusades, the insistence on being right—is, in some way, shaped by that grape-juice midnight in the kitchen and the bowl in my hand. There is a kind of certainty that loves something so much it kills it. You can trace it from a four-year-old with three chicks to a grown man with an unshakable sense of being on the correct side of a theological war. I am not sure I ever entirely stopped being the boy with the bowl. That was the last straw. I lost my bedroom. I was moved in with my brother Jarred, who was fourteen and did not want me there, and whose teenage body odor reeked like, as I privately described it at the time, the bowels of Hell. The nursery warmth was gone. The Shangri-La years were ending.

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The summer of 1978, my sister Violet was born. I was about to start kindergarten. All the things that had made my childhood what it was—lakeside breakfasts of Rice Krispies with Ninapa and Grace, fishing off the dock with Aunt Irene, family Rosaries on the back porch as the lightning storms rolled across Oneida Lake, family "tv nights" watching episodes of *The Waltons* and *Little House on the Prairie*—were entering their last rotation without me knowing.

One August morning, Ninapa and I were fishing off the dock. He had hardly spoken for an hour, which was his way. Then, apropos of nothing, he said:

"'Red sky in morning, sailors take warning.' It means if you see a red sky to the west in the morning, a storm's coming. A red sky at night means tomorrow'll be nice."

"Is there a storm coming?"

"Not right now, Mr. Why-Why. Probably tonight."

That night our family converged on the weathered back porch, the air thick with the scent of grilled burgers and fading daylight. We clutched our rosary beads, their smooth surfaces warmed by our hands, and murmured prayers in unison, our voices a soft cadence against the restless hum of cicadas. Out on the lake a thunderstorm prowled, its massive, churning clouds—charcoal-gray and swollen with menace—unfurling like a tattered curtain across the sky. Lightning flickered within, jagged and fleeting, a pauper's fireworks display that lit the water in ghostly bursts. I never paused to consider how those towering, billowing storm clouds, heavy with unspoken warnings, were a prelude to the tempests soon to break over our lives.

Chapter 5

Red Sky at Morning

The conflict between the generations is as old as the hills, and it's always about the same thing: freedom. —Margaret Mead

August 20th 1978

Bridgeport, New York

A few nights after Ninapa told me the red sky was a storm warning, the storm arrived. I was in bed, just under, when our family's cherry-red Jeep screeched into the gravel driveway, tires spitting stones. My brother Pete and my sister Joan exploded out of it, Joan screaming as she came up the walk.

"He's going to kill Pete!"

Before my father could get to the door, a second car came up the driveway—a hulking dust-streaked sedan—and a man the size of a barn got out of it and walked straight through the open garage door after Pete, saying as he came, "You little bastard. Don't you know how to dim your high beams? You're begging for a beating."

My siblings and I stacked up at the windows like an audience. It did not yet occur to any of us that this was real.

"Peter, grab your gun!" my mother shouted.

My father—wiry, a man who had once been a boxer and had never stopped being one inside—came through the inner door into the garage holding a shotgun in his hands. The stranger had Pete cornered against the pegboard wall. My father leveled the gun at the man and told him to get out.

The man misread my father, as many had before him. He lunged for the gun, and they grappled with it in the middle of the garage, the barrel twisting back and forth

between them. My sisters were crying. My father, without hesitation, drove the butt of the shotgun up into the intruder's mouth. The man staggered back, bleeding. My father tossed the gun aside onto the concrete floor. He had the shape of the rest of it already decided in his body.

What followed took less than a minute, and none of us who saw it ever forgot it. My father was a trained fighter, and what he gave that man was a boxer's answer: a flurry of jabs, straight crosses, and hooks, all landed with the kind of furious speed and grace that only comes from years at the heavy bag. Nothing wild. Nothing drunk. Just punches in the right order to the right targets. The first jab opened the stranger's guard; the cross that came behind it rocked his head back; the hook that came behind the cross caught him under the jaw and drove him out of the garage and into the driveway backwards. He tried once to put his hands up. My father went around them. By the time the stranger hit the side of his own sedan, his face was already a ruin, and he slid down the door panel to the gravel and did not get up. My siblings were cheering from the windows—"Go, Dad!"—the way kids cheer when the wrong team is losing badly, which is to say, with no understanding at all of what they are watching. I was five.

Uncle Duke's pickup came up the drive as the fight ended. Duke got out, looked at the man on the gravel, looked at my father, and said something that amounted to "Guess you didn't need me." The two of them hauled the stranger into the back seat of his own car, drove him to the edge of town, and left him on the shoulder, with the same warning delivered twice in two voices: come back and it is the last thing you ever do.

My father walked back into the house with both hands ruined. His knuckles were split from landing on the man's teeth. For a week after, he soaked them in basins of Epsom salt. He did not talk about it at the dinner table. Nobody did.

I understand now what that night was. It was the hinge. Everything in my life up to that point had been the gold of my grandfather's Rice Krispies and the sound of my siblings playing records upstairs, and everything after began to organize itself around the fact that there were men like the one in the driveway, and the world could no longer be treated as Shangri-La, because the driveway had breached it. My parents had been feeling this for months in their own registers, watching the culture move and the Church shift. That night just showed it to them in a form they could not look away from.

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Motivated by the desire to have steady work to provide for his growing family, my father ran for Business Agent of Steamfitters Local 267 and won the seat younger than anyone ever had. The money was steady and the benefits covered us, which was what they had needed in the year of Violet's birth. What the job also covered, which he had not known to anticipate, was an endless stream of unemployed men phoning him at all hours asking him to make jobs appear—a role, for a man who had hated arguing all his life, that cost him most of his remaining peace. Within a few years it would cost him his relationship with his brother Ray. But in the fall of 1978 that was still ahead.

Everything else was also moving. At the parish schools my older siblings attended, the nuns had stopped wearing habits, confession was no longer required before First Communion, and by that October my mother came home to tell my father that the drama club at St. Mary's in Minoa was planning to stage *Jesus Christ Superstar*. My father, who could already name the rock musical from the talk of it in the Catholic press, took the news the way another man might have taken news: that his house was on fire. It was, in his view, sacrilege, and it was happening at a Catholic school—the precise thing that the Virgin at Garabandal had warned about—and the school's administration did not see what the problem was. He and my mother protested. They

were met with the same shrug he had gotten at St. Francis the year before from a priest who saw no problem with receiving Communion twice in a day. It would not be the last shrug.

Around the same time, a woman my parents knew through their Right to Life circle had called their diocesan Birthright office posing as a pregnant mother of seven, and the woman at the desk had given her the phone number for Planned Parenthood. My parents brought it to the bishop of Syracuse. The bishop shrugged it off. My father, as a real union man, knew the power of organizing and protest—he was going to picket the bishop of Syracuse. He led a group outside the Syracuse Chancery in 1977 with signs. The local media covered it. The story got picked up nationally, and by the end of the week the bishop announced in *The Catholic Sun* that the woman was no longer employed, though he continued to deny she had made referrals. It was a partial victory, and it reinforced in my father something he already more than half believed: that if you wanted the Church to act right on the things it should act right about, you were going to have to break some eggs. This was, he understood later, not how a faithful Catholic was meant to relate to his bishop. But his bishop had not given him another option.

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At home, the older kids were slipping the leash. Joan, just sixteen, had decided my parents should have stopped having children after Lisa. Her body language said this every time my mother got pregnant again. Pete, seventeen, the one everyone called "Genius" for his grades, was suspected of sneaking out of his bedroom window after a tattle from Donna. My father confronted him, "Pete, have you been sneaking out at night?" Pete, ever honest, denied it with a straight face. "No, dad. I wouldn't do that."

One muggy summer night a few weeks later, my father roused to use the bathroom and on a hunch he decided to check on Pete. He crept to his room, opened his door, and

saw where moonlight spilled through an open window, stirring the sheer curtains. Pete's form lay snug under a quilt, an unusually warm blanket for such a warm night. My father's instincts kicked in. He approached the bed, only to find a wig atop balled-up clothes —a decoy. Pete was gone.

Fury simmering, my father dismantled the faux Pete and decided to climb into Pete's bed and wait. At 3 a.m., Pete, reeking of cheap booze, clambered through the window, his movements clumsy but stealthy. He reached for his "dummy," only to freeze when the blanket stirred. "Good morning, Pete," my father rumbled, his voice a seismic tremor. "Did you have fun?" Pete later swore he nearly soiled himself. The punishment was swift and unforgettable.

Jarred, at fourteen, had come home from somewhere with a KISS album and a small alarm-clock radio he had bought with his own money, and had begun to spend most of his free time in his bedroom with the door closed. My mother told my father she was worried. My father took the album and the radio and walked them out of the house. Jarred was furious. "I bought that radio with my own money." "Yeah, well, you're using my electricity." The radio went to my father's office. It sat there for fourteen years. Then one Christmas in the early 1990s, my father handed Jarred a large gift-wrapped box with a red bow. Jarred opened it, dug through the tissue paper, and found, at the bottom, his radio. "Merry Christmas, Jarred," my father said, and laughed until he cried.

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One Sunday morning in the spring of 1979—I was six, in plaid pants and a red sweater vest—my whole family piled into our brown Chevy van for Mass. We assumed we were driving the five minutes down Route 298 to St. Francis of Assisi, our parish. My father drove past St. Francis without slowing down. He kept driving south. My mother, in the passenger seat, was running a rosary through her fingers.

"Dad, we missed church."

"No we didn't," he said, quietly. "We're going to a different Mass."

"What do you mean we're not going to St. Francis?" Joan snapped from the back. "It's five minutes away. All our friends go there."

He kept his eyes on the road. "Because St. Francis doesn't have the real Mass anymore. They took the altar out, turned the priest around, and started playing guitars. If we want the Mass the Church gave us—the one that's been said the same way for centuries—we have to drive to Fr. Hattala's in Homer. That's where we're going."

Joan began to argue. He cut her off. "Joan, do you want to know the real reason we're driving an hour past a perfectly good church?"

"Yes."

The van got quiet. Even the baby stopped fussing.

"Let me tell you a story about Pope Leo. In 1884," my father said, "Pope Leo XIII had just finished saying Mass in his private chapel in Rome. He turned to step down from the altar, and the room changed. And he heard two voices, louder than thunder, coming from over the tabernacle. The first was ugly. Proud. Full of hate. It was the devil, speaking to God the Father. The devil said: 'Give me one century. One hundred years. And with the people you created, I'll destroy your Church. I'll use your own priests and bishops. I'll sit in your temple and be worshipped as God.'

"Then the second voice answered. Quiet. Calm. It was Jesus. He said: 'My Father has already granted your request. You shall have your century, and greater power over those who serve you. But remember: my Mother will crush your head, and the gates of Hell will never prevail against my Church.'"

My father looked up into the rearview mirror at all of us.

"Pope Leo collapsed on the altar steps, and when they carried him to a chair, the first thing out of his mouth was 'Paper. Bring me paper.' Still shaking, he wrote the Prayer to Saint Michael—'Saint Michael the Archangel, defend us in battle, be our protection against the wickedness and snares of the devil'—and ordered it said after every Low Mass in the world, every day, in perpetuity. That order stood for almost eighty years. Until 1964, when they quietly told priests they could drop it. Right in the middle of the devil's hundred years."

He held our eyes in the mirror.

"That's why we're going to Homer."

He did not say anything else for the rest of the drive. None of us did. I stared out the van window at barns and silos I had never seen before while the Prayer to Saint Michael rearranged itself in my six-year-old head, and by the time we pulled into the driveway of an unremarkable ranch house in Homer, New York, I was braced for the basement to open into a cathedral.

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It did not. A kindly older woman, the priest's housekeeper, met us at the side door and led us in through the garage to a set of basement stairs. Above the stairs a small hand-lettered sign read: *You are entering the catacombs.*

The basement chapel was cramped and musty, the air a mix of damp concrete and incense. Twenty or thirty people were already there, almost all of them old—the men in suits that had been good thirty years ago, the women with lace mantillas on their heads—and a handful of young families like ours who had come from across central New York. Fr. Hattala, an elderly retired priest, came out in black vestments and began the Mass with his back to us, in Latin. I did not understand a word of it. I understood that he understood it. I understood that the old people around us understood it. I

understood, in that new and strange way a six-year-old understands things, that my family had become strangers to the church we had been driving past my entire life and that we were now kneeling in a room beneath a stranger's house because, my father had said, this was the real one. The catacombs sign, whatever my father had intended by it, was the part of that day I took home with me.

After Mass the community gathered at the fire station down the road for pancakes. It was there, over stacks of syrup-soaked pancakes on paper plates, that my father met Dr. Wayne Amato, a fellow traditionalist and Right to Life crusader from the Syracuse area who would become his closest friend for the next decade—a reader of every traditionalist book in print, and a man who quickly pressed into my father's hands a copy of *The Rhine Flows into the Tiber* and told him to read it and be afraid. They talked about the Antichrist. They talked about Freemasons in the Vatican. To my six-year-old ears it sounded like my father's Rasputin story at the Christmas rosary five years earlier, which is to say, it sounded like a myth I was being allowed inside of. I did not yet know how to worry about a thing I was being told made me special to know.

We never went back to St. Francis. For the next several years every Sunday meant the hour-long drive to Homer, past the spire of our old parish, past every friend my siblings had grown up with, on the way to a basement beneath a stranger's house. For my sister Joan, this was too much.

Joan's rebellion peaked in the spring of 1979. Working at an A&W, she quit abruptly, claiming her boss was unbearable. Then she began hovering by the phone, answering every call with suspicious urgency. My mother, sensing deception, confronted her. Joan brushed it off, but the truth emerged when her former manager called, demanding the return of three uniforms. He revealed Joan had been dodging his calls, hanging up whenever he rang.

My father, livid, ordered Joan to gather the uniforms. She refused, defiance flashing in her eyes. "Joan, get them, or else," he growled, his Darth Vader voice in full force. He waited in the car, honking impatiently. When he returned, finding Joan unmoved on her bed, the tension snapped. "YES, YOU ARE!" he roared, grabbing her arm. Joan collapsed, kicking and flailing, striking his shin. In a flash, he pulled her over his lap and spanked her until her resistance broke. Tear-streaked, she complied, returning the uniforms in silence.

Weeks later, Joan descended the stairs with two suitcases, her face set with resolve. She had found an apartment and was leaving that morning. My mother stood frozen, stunned by the suddenness. Joan, the most devout of my siblings, rejected my parents' rigid traditionalism. To her, it was the 1970s—the Church's springtime—and they were clinging to a fading past.

A few months after moving out, Joan met a man named Neil at a bar, told him up front that she only dated Catholics, and within a year was engaged to him. My parents, who had decided—on limited evidence and too much certainty—that Joan and Neil were living together before the wedding, refused to attend. Only Pete, Donna, and Jarred went. My Aunt Irene, Joan's godmother, was so furious with my parents for not going that she and Uncle Sam sold their lakeside house later that year, built a smaller place for Ninapa on the back lot, and left. The compound my grandparents had dreamed of—the whole idea of the family settled on one shoreline—began to come apart. My father saw this as the cost of standing firm. My mother, I think, grieved it without ever quite saying so aloud.

Joan's was the only one of my siblings' weddings my parents would ever skip. Joan was one of the few siblings to keep her virginity until her wedding. That fact should have told my father something. It did not. His eyes were fixed on a hundred-year war

between the forces of heaven and hell, and he was a true believer that he was fighting for God. He did not consider casualties around him yet.

The morning sky of my childhood had turned to a deep red.

Chapter 6

The Siege of Alcázar

All cruelty springs from weakness. — Seneca

January 1979

Bridgeport, New York

After the death of Donna's chicks, I was relegated to bunking with my brother Jarred. Mornings in our shared room were pure torture. School days kicked off with Jarred's stereo blasting, shattering my sleep. I'd crack open my eyes to find him strutting around like Mick Jagger, lip-syncing into a hairbrush like a wannabe rock star, belting out REO Speedwagon with exaggerated swagger:

"Ya take it on the run, bae-bay! If that's the way you want it, bae-bay!"

Then he'd lunge, planting his face three inches from mine, his breath a rancid cloud of teenage morning funk, and growl, *"Then I don't want you around!"* The worst part was his body odor, a sour mix of sweat and cheap deodorant, which made my stomach churn.

Some mornings, he'd escalate the assault, picking his nose with theatrical flair. "Oh, look at this one!" he'd crow, dangling a booger in my face. "Get outta bed, loser, or you'll be late for school!"

On the first day of kindergarten at St. Mary's in Minoa, our teacher Mrs. Sobol took attendance. When she got to the name "Guy Hart" I turned around in my seat, certain that a Muppet had enrolled in our class. What I saw instead was a slight olive-skinned boy who had smiled broadly at hearing his own name and was already fidgeting in his chair. He was not a Muppet, but he gave off Muppet vibes, and when we learned at lunch that he and I were the only two kindergartners who lived in Bridgeport—which

meant, because of the half-day schedule, that he and I would ride the little short bus home alone together every day for an entire school year—my life changed.

We were two peas in a pod. We both loved *Star Wars* and *Battlestar Galactica*. His favorite characters were Han Solo and Starbuck, the two swashbucklers. Mine were Luke Skywalker and Apollo, the two idealists—a difference in taste that, looking back, may have explained everything else about us. On the short bus ride home each afternoon, just the two of us, we made up new episodes of *Battlestar Galactica* in which our six-year-old selves flew Vipers against Cylons down Route 298. Those afternoons were the best part of my kindergarten year, and they carried me through the worst part, which arrived in the form of a nun named Sister Catherine.

Sister Catherine was St. Mary's Elementary's principal, and the embodiment of every whispered tale about mean nuns. She was five-foot-two and a hundred pounds in black veil and starched white habit, and her shoes clicked on the linoleum like a countdown. She patrolled the cafeteria with a black poodle named Gigi who nipped at any child whose shoes were untied. Her punishments were baroque and imaginative—she once made an entire class shove a door open repeatedly to trap a "misbehaving" student behind it, then asked the trapped child, "Do you like that attention now?" She ran recess and lunch, which meant she saw every child in the school at least twice a day.

I was one of her favorite targets. I do not know why; I suspect it was that I was too preoccupied with trying to make other kids laugh, and she read that as defiance. She began pulling my hair. Not once, not in bursts; every day, at the back of my scalp, a twist that became the first thing I braced for at the start of each school morning. Thanks to Sister Catherine, I quickly formed a deep hatred of school. By the middle of first grade, a bald patch had formed on my head.

My mother found it one evening during a bath. She stopped scrubbing, called my father into the bathroom, and asked me quietly whether someone was pulling my hair. I told the truth. The next morning my father told my sisters Lisa and Marie he'd drive us to school. At the drop-off he said goodbye to them, rested his hand on the back of my neck, and steered me directly into the principal's office.

Sister Catherine looked up from her desk, saw my father, and her face changed. The scowl I had learned to dread softened into something that tried very hard to look like warmth. "Mr. Massett," she said, her voice pitched about two octaves higher than I had ever heard it. "How aaarrre you?"

My father did not sit down. He turned my head with one hand and parted my hair to show her the bald spot.

"Sister," he said, and the voice that came out of him was the slow, deep, Darth Vaderesque voice all six of us siblings recognized and feared. "Explain to me why my six-year-old son has a bald spot on the back of his head."

There was a long silence as Sister Catherine tried to process my father's question under the weight of his imposing presence.

"Oh my goodness," she gasped, her hands to her mouth. "How did that happen?"

"You should know, Sister Catherine. You did it."

Her mouth opened and then closed. She had, in her face, the same frozen expression I had seen my siblings wear when my father caught them lying. It was, for me, a revelation—the first time I had watched an adult I feared be held accountable by another adult, and it was my father doing it. He sent me to class and stayed behind with her. Whatever he said to her, she never touched me again. That night he leaned down to

me in the kitchen and said quietly: "If she ever pulls your hair again, you tell me." And that was the end of Sister Catherine's reign of terror.

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My birthday, January 22, was not only the anniversary of Roe v. Wade. It was also, every year, the date my parents flew to Washington for the March for Life—a collision of calendars that meant my parents were never home on my birthday through my entire childhood. In kindergarten this was especially cruel, because kindergarten had a rite: on your birthday you brought in cupcakes for the class. All year I had watched the bearers of cupcakes ascend into social royalty, and I had watched the empty-handed cast out. I did not intend to be cast out.

The night before my sixth birthday my mother promised me that Donna, who was watching us while my parents flew south, would have my strawberry cupcakes frosted and ready for me by morning. When I woke up, the cupcakes were there on the counter with pink frosting swirled like sunset clouds, and I nearly wept with relief. Then Donna, getting me dressed for school at speed, handed me the tray covered in wax paper instead of plastic wrap.

"Mommy said plastic because it's raining. No time. Run, or you'll miss the bus."

Outside, freezing rain. A half mile to the bus stop on Esther Avenue. I ran. By the time I got there the bus had not arrived and my strawberry cupcakes were a pink sludge of dissolving wax paper and melted frosting. When the bus finally came I sat in the front seat, not looking at the tray on my lap. Guy Hart got on at his stop, sat next to me, took one look at what I was carrying, and said the words every St. Marys kindergartner dreads.

"Ew. Those cupcakes look disgusting!"

At school, I shuffled to my spot in line, the cupcake tray a shameful weight in my hands. My classmates' eyes lit up at first, their smiles and thumbs-ups a cruel lease. But when I reached Ms. Sobel's desk, the truth spilled out. She peeled back the sodden wax paper, revealing my disaster. "What do we have here?" she asked, her tone a mix of pity and disbelief. The room's warmth turned icy as whispers spread. My classmates' faces twisted with disgust, as if I'd offered them poison. Ms. Sobel tossed the cupcakes into the trash, each one landing with a dull thud, burying my dreams of acceptance in a landfill of contempt.

By day's end, Billy Stewart, the self-appointed kindergarten king, rallied the class to declare me unworthy of their friendship. As we packed up to leave, he cornered Guy by our cubbies. "C'mon, Guy, we're not friends with Louie."

Guy's brow furrowed. "Louie's my best friend."

Billy, backed by his posse, sneered. "Then you're not our friend either."

Guy shrugged, his smile unshaken. "Okay."

Billy blinked, stunned by Guy's defiance.

The other kids, bewildered by a thing that was not supposed to be allowed to happen, scattered. Guy and I got on the short bus and rode home. That day, January 22, 1979, I learned what it meant to have a brother who was not of the same flesh and blood, but one of spirit. I have thought about that shrug of Guy's more times than I can count over the years since. Everything I know about loyalty, I know because a six-year-old boy shrugged.

My friendship with Guy blossomed quickly, so much so that we spent a great deal of time together that first year. I spent most of the following summer at the Hart home. This friendship lent itself to our mothers becoming fast friends as Guy's younger sister Missy was the same age as my sisters Nellie and Violet. Both of our mothers were

devout Catholics who around the same time discovered their baby girls had serious health issues.

My youngest sister Violet had begun, around age two, to have unexplained seizures. Her doctors warned that uncontrolled seizures at that age could cause permanent neurological damage. My parents, terrified, did a pilgrimage to the North American Martyrs' Shrine in Auriesville seeking Divine assistance. Violet's condition made her irritable and she was particularly fussy during Mass. My father carried her to the back of the basilica to minimize the distraction. To his great amazement, he saw that Conchita, one of the four Garabandal visionaries, was also standing in the back nursing her own child. My father, who had met her at Garabandal ten years earlier, could not help but think this was a sign. He interrupted her, begging for any help she might offer. Against her obvious annoyance at being interrupted during Mass by an American stranger, she dug into her purse and pulled out a pectoral cross, "This belonged to Padre Pio," she whispered. She pressed it to Violet's forehead and prayed three Hail Marys. Violet's seizures ceased that afternoon. At her next appointment, the pediatric neurologist, a confirmed atheist named Dr. Monreall, ordered a CAT scan, read the clean results, and wrote on Violet's chart the word *Miracle*. He had never seen anything like it.

A few months later, in January of 1980, the Harts found a tumor wrapped around the aorta of Guy's baby sister Missy. She was almost two. Her prognosis, like Violet's, was bleak. A year later, in February 1981, a charismatic priest named Fr. Ralph DiOrio prayed over her, asking for God's healing. At her next MRI the tumor was gone, completely gone. Her oncologist had no explanation.

Both of our families got what they had asked heaven for, but from different paths. The initial challenges brought our mothers into a deep friendship. They relied on each other for support. For my father, Violet's healing only reinforced his belief in

Garabandal and its message that Cardinals and bishops would lead souls to Hell; whereas the Harts were drawn deeper into the Charismatic movement, which focused heavily on miracles, prophecy, and speaking in tongues. The answers to our parents' prayers ultimately drove our two families in opposite directions. Within a few years, my father would consider the charismatic movement a dangerous delusion, Mrs. Hart would consider Traditionalism a spiritual cul-de-sac, and the friendship between two families who had been each other's lifelines through two childhood illnesses would begin, quietly, to fray.

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By then my father was deeply immersed in the Traditionalist controversy. Dr. Wayne Amato had given him a copy of *Apologia Pro Marcel Lefebvre* by Michael Davies, and my father devoured it in his recliner across three nights, followed by a second volume across two more. It was obvious to us all how important the subject of traditionalism had become to my father. Sometimes we'd have Father Michael Jarecki come and say the Latin Mass in our house and I would serve as an altar boy who didn't have a clue what he was doing. Fr. Jarecki would give me the high sign when it was time for me to ring the bell. I could see how my father lit up during these moments.

My father's other great passion was hunting and fishing. One Friday during the summer months, he drove me up to the Adirondacks to fish with his friend Freddie Handley and Freddie's sons—an excursion I had said yes to entirely on the promise of riding four-wheelers. What I didn't expect was that my father, who almost never told me what he was thinking, would talk to me the whole three-hour drive.

"Dad, what's that book Dr. Amato gave you?"

"It's about Archbishop Lefebvre. He's fighting to keep the Church straight against these Modernist types—guys who water down the faith, chasing trends instead of truth."

"Modernists?"

"They think truth shifts with whatever's popular. Like saying abortion's not always wrong. They bend Church teachings to fit feelings, not what's been taught for centuries."

I nodded, mostly not understanding. What I understood was that my father was talking to me—at ten years old, this was not a small thing—and I held on with both hands.

"So Lefebvre's like Obi-Wan Kenobi?"

He laughed, a short laugh. "Close enough, Louie. The Society of St. Pius X, they go around offering people the real Mass, teaching solid Catholic doctrine to protect folks from these Modernist mistakes."

"Mrs. Hart said Vatican II was guided by the Holy Spirit. How can we go against the Pope?"

His jaw tightened. "Vatican II's not set in stone, Lou. It's pastoral, not absolute dogma. We can question it. Lefebvre's getting hammered for telling it like it is."

The dirt road to the camp came up on our right. He cut the engine before he turned in, looked at me dead straight, and said, "This fight's bigger than where we go to Mass, Lou. It's about the Church's soul. Lefebvre's trying to keep the faith pure, the way it's been for ages."

We sat in silence with the Adirondacks around us. I have thought about that silence many times since. He was letting me in for the first time in my life on what the fight

meant to him. I was hearing a ten-year-old's version of a thing that was going to organize the rest of my childhood, and I didn't know that I was being handed a weapon. My father was a persuasive speaker, and he talked about this topic with conviction and certainty. It was a topic that interested me as well, and it didn't hurt that he had talked to me the whole drive up.

Hunting trips to the Adirondacks had been a rite of passage for my father, and helped build a strong bond with his own father. Naturally, he tried to pass this on to his sons.

The first time my father took me hunting was at Copper Lake, a camp on an island that could only be reached by hiking three miles along a foot trail and then rowing the last quarter mile in a little aluminum boat. I was eleven. I had grown up on his stories of hunting with my grandfather—the camp, the cold, the pride of the first deer—and I wanted to love it the way he had.

At five the first morning, the cabin was fifty degrees inside. I dragged myself out of the sleeping bag and dressed by the wood stove while my father made pancakes and bacon. Then we went out into a foot of new snow on top of the foot already there, and I learned in the first mile that hunting with my father was not what the stories had been. He handed me his wristwatch after an hour and told me to stand alone until seven, then walk west through the trees and bark and howl to drive any deer toward him. I stood there for the longest hour of my eleven-year-old life. The whole day passed that way. I did not see a deer. Halfway through, to keep myself sane, I stuck two broken pine branches into my hat and began singing "Rudolph the Red-Nosed Reindeer" at full volume as I drove. When my father finally saw me—antlered, singing—he laughed.

I was famished by the time we returned to the cabin. To my relief, Freddy Hanley had dinner ready: hamburgers, hashbrowns, and onions. Halfway through eating my hamburger, Freddy said, "Like that burger, Louie? Amazing how good it tastes

considering how much rotten meat I had to scrape off." I froze halfway through chewing and looked down at the burger being held up between my hands. My father and Freddy burst out laughing. I chuckled half heartedly, relieved at realizing it was a joke.

My appreciation for Freddy's humor evaporated after throwing up multiple times that night. I was convinced it was food poisoning. In my mind the entire expedition was a total disaster.

The next morning we snowmobiled three miles back to the road so we could make Mass at the SSPX chapel in Utica. Miss Mass at your own peril—my father had inherited that from his father. Just outside of Utica, a driver cut us off and nearly ran us onto the shoulder. My father's neck went red. He pulled alongside and pointed at the shoulder. Pull over. The other driver pointed back—happy to. Both cars began to roll onto the gravel.

I was half-asleep in the passenger seat but quickly came to realize what was about to happen and was mortified. I put my hand on my father's arm. "Dad, Catholics don't fight this way."

My father looked at me and his expression softened. He pulled the truck back onto the road and kept driving. He did not say anything for a mile. Years later he confessed that this moment touched him. The lesson he drew from it was about me. He did not draw the one about himself.

The second time I went out hunting with my father was a hunting lodge at Long Lake with his brother, my Uncle Duke. We took a small motor boat for a long, bitter cold thirty-minute drive across the lake. It was the coldest thirty minutes of my life. We hiked for a good hour into the Adirondack wilderness. At around eight-thirty a.m. we arrived at a four-foot deep brook that was just wide enough for us to jump. My father

went first and turned to offer me a hand. I tried to jump a three-foot brook with my hands in my pockets, planted my foot at a bad angle, and plunged backwards into the water to the waist. My father dragged me out, helped me out of my wet layers, hung mine on a frame over a fire, and gave me his long johns. I thought the boat ride was cold—that was nothing. I had never been more uncomfortable in my entire life. I assumed that once my pants were dry we would begin the one-hour walk back to camp for dry clothes, but to my surprise he told me we would keep hunting the rest of the day once the clothes were "dry enough." They were not dry. We hunted. My teeth did not stop chattering until sunset. It was pure hell.

At sundown we arrived at the lean-to where we were to meet Uncle Duke, but he was not there. We waited for fifteen minutes. The wind was whipping across the lake, making my discomfort unbearable, my teeth chatter sounding like something out of a Warner Brothers cartoon. My father, fearing for my well being, put me in the bow of the boat and told me to watch the ridge for a light. "If you see a light, it'll be your Uncle. Let me know and we'll go back and get him." Halfway across I saw the bounce of a flashlight coming down the ridge. I deliberated. I thought about how damn cold I was, about the wind on my wet pants, about hell. I had been meditating on hell most of the day. Nevertheless, I raised my arm and pointed. My father turned the boat.

At supper that night my father told the story of the plunge into the icy brook, imitating my stammer—"D-d-daaaad,"—and the men at the table laughed the way men at a hunting table laugh. Even then I could understand and recognize the idea of "toughing up." Ninapa was no-nonsense about what it took to be a man. The hardship of marching all day in damp clothes wasn't what I found difficult—it was what I felt was my father's indifference.

It made me think of the story my father told us about Col. Jose Moscardó Ituarte and the siege of Alcázar fortress against Communists during the Spanish Civil War. The

Communist Republican army had captured Ituarte's 17 year old son Luis Moscardó Guzmán and forced him to call his father and tell him they would kill him if he did not surrender the fort. Ituarte's last words to his son were: "Muere como un hombre" — "Die like a man." I could see my father's admiration for Ituarte, and that he too would have no problem sacrificing his children for the cause. In his mind this was the Catholic way. I understood how little my life meant with respect to the causes that inspired him. That was the last time I ever went deer hunting with my father.

Chapter 7

A Bitter Zeal

Men never do evil so completely and cheerfully as when they do it from religious conviction. —Blaise Pascal

In the spring of 1985, I lay in bed one Saturday night listening through the wall to my father on the phone. His voice was not the voice I knew. It was high and boyish, almost giddy.

"Oh, this is just so wonderful," he said. "Thank you, Fr. Williamson. Yes—we can have Mass at our Union Hall. It seats a hundred people, easy."

I had never heard my father that happy. The joy of it carried through the wall like the joy that comes off a man who has found his team. Fr. Richard Williamson was the rector of the Society of St. Pius X seminary in Ridgefield, Connecticut—an English-born, Oxford-educated priest with a gray widow's peak and a cassock that swept the floor. What had turned my father giddy was that Williamson had agreed to begin saying Mass once a month at Local 267's union hall in Syracuse.

A cold little knot formed in my twelve-year-old stomach at the idea. Mass in a union hall, the same room where my father spent his weekdays taking angry phone calls from jobless pipefitters, smelled wrong to me in a way I couldn't name—a sacred thing being held inside a room that smelled of stale coffee and contract disputes. But my father's joy was so complete that I did not say anything to anyone about it. I rolled over and went to sleep. Williamson was coming.

Fr. Williamson came to our house for dinner a week before his first Union Hall Mass. When I opened the front door that Saturday evening, the man standing on our porch was the tallest priest I had ever seen. Gaunt, gray-haired, his cassock pooling around his feet, his English vowels landing on our foyer rug like someone had invited

Gandalf in from the night. He looked at me, took in my name from my father, and from that moment onward he was the first priest in my life who I believed actually saw me. Every other priest I had met had been pleasant, interchangeable, forgettable. Williamson was not. Williamson was playing for keeps.

At dinner my father was a version of himself I hadn't known existed. He was charming. He was deferential. He was, for the first time in my memory, nervous in front of another man. When the dishes were cleared he leaned forward and asked, in a voice that wobbled with hope: "Fr. Williamson, would you tell the children a story about the saints?"

Williamson smiled a small, private smile. "Sure, sure," he said. "I wonder if you children have heard the story of the Curé of Ars—St. John Marie Vianney?"

"No," we chorused, leaning in.

"Well." He folded his long hands. "He was an extraordinary priest. So extraordinary that the devil himself once declared that if there were five more like him, his kingdom would crumble. The devil hated the Curé. He despised him so much that at night he would come to the rectory and physically attack him—throwing him around, trying to exhaust him, trying to break his spirit so he could not hear confession the next day. Because confession was the Curé's work, you see. People came from all over France for him. They stood in the line for hours. The Curé would sit in that confession box for twelve, fourteen, sixteen hours a day, drawing souls out of hell one-by-one. And the devil could not bear it. He sifted the Curé, but the Curé did not break. The Curé would taunt him. 'Is that all you've got, Scratch?' he'd say—that's what he called the devil. 'Scratch.' He was unbreakable.

"That's what priests need today," Williamson said, and his eyes, which had been on the table, lifted to my father's. "That's what the Society fights for. The Faith is under

siege. Satan is throwing priests around, and they are falling, and the people no longer know right from wrong. It is a terrible problem. A terrible problem. That's why the Society exists."

We sat at that table like children at a campfire. I was twelve years old and I understood, with something that felt like recognition rather than conviction, that the man across the table from my father had given my father a name for everything that had been eating at him. I understood also, without being able to say it, that my father was now Williamson's, in a way he had never previously been anyone's.

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The following morning, the union hall was an altar. Fr. Williamson, in full black cassock and gold vestments, turned his back to a hundred of us and offered the Tridentine Mass on a folding table draped in white linen. My Uncle Duke and Al Van Auker and the Farrells were there. Families I did not recognize had come from across central New York because the word had gone out that Williamson was saying Mass at the union hall on Sunday. His homily that morning did not discuss the Gospel. His homily denounced Rome. It named bishops. It named a pope. It rang off the cinderblock walls of Local 267 the way the strike speeches had once rung off those same walls, and the congregation—half of whom I had known all my life, and half of whom were strangers to me—nodded and wept and received Communion on their tongues from a priest the Pope of Rome had in 1976 forbidden to say Mass at all.

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By that spring my parents were all-in on the SSPX and began promoting it to everyone they could. The SSPX had the answers to the crisis in the Church and society at large. Our family had become close with the Farrells, the Van Aukens, and the Harts who were all Catholic. My mother and Mrs. Farrell had sat across kitchen tables from

each other for as long as I had memories. Al Van Auken was my father's distant cousin and had been his friend since their youth.

The SSPX message landed in each family differently. Mrs. Farrell took to it quickly — the Farrells were small-c conservative by temperament, and what they had been watching in the post-Vatican-II Church had already unsettled them. My father's cousin Al treated my father as if he were Moses coming down from mount Siani. He took to it faster and harder than anyone, hungry for the certainty he had been looking for since his mother died when he was five.

The Harts were a different matter. Mr. and Mrs. Hart had been formed by Catholic schools and college, they had found their religious home in the charismatic renewal — the speaking in tongues, the healing Masses, Fr. DiOrio in Schenectady — and to them Vatican II was not a rupture, but a springtime. Mrs. Hart said the line once at my mother's kitchen table and it became the line by which I always thereafter understood what was at stake between our two families: "You can't be more Catholic than the Pope, Bonnie."

My mother did not answer her. But after Mrs. Hart went home that day, my mother stood at the sink a long time, rinsing a coffee cup that was already clean.

Van Auken was the one who was most moved by the Traditionalist sales pitch — the son of a mother who had died when he was five and a father who had never recovered. He took to my father and Lefebvre as father figures with the particular hunger of an orphan. Al was all-in on the fight against the Modernism in the Church. His wife Judy, on the other hand, had found her way into the charismatic renewal. This created a major rift. Al went from mild-mannered Mass goer to a zealot overnight, which caused massive marital problems. The more SSPX literature he read, the more zealous he became. Things became so bad that Al refused to attend his daughters her First

Communion at Judy's Novus Ordo parish. One night Judy asked him whether he love her anymore, and Al answered with a line that could have come out of a Lefebvre pamphlet: "How could I love a Modernist?" He let his wife and his seven-year-old walk into that church alone on the most important day of her childhood faith, rather than kneel in a pew that was, in his reading, theologically wrong. She left him shortly after, with their children, fearing for their safety. My family, including my father, found the departure unthinkable. Nobody in the family, as far as I could tell at the time, found the First Communion unthinkable. That asymmetry was its own warning, and none of us knew how to read it. It was the first case in our orbit of the radicalism producing the kind of domestic ruin it was supposedly a bulwark against. It would not be the last.

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Before each Mass, my father laid out a table of pamphlets Williamson sent him by the box—tracts that promised to answer every question a confused modern Catholic might bring into the hall. *Is the Novus Ordo Mass Valid?* was the title that drew the longest glances from visitors. Williamson's sermons, meanwhile, had been widening out over the months into something less like homilies and more like a weekly map of an enemy order. The Freemasons had infiltrated the Vatican. International Jewry had financed the Bolshevik revolution. The Communists had placed agents inside the American seminaries in the 1950s. *The Sound of Music* was "sentimental hogwash." Pants on women were "a modernist ploy to erase the God-given order between men and women." Within three Sundays every girl and woman in our hall was in a skirt. I would not, for another thirty-five years, see my own mother in pants.

My father accepted all of it without weighing any of it. That is what I saw, then and later. He did not read Williamson skeptically the way he read other men. He read him the way you read a man you have elected to trust without reservation—which is to say, he did not really read him at all. What Williamson said, my father carried home and

began saying. The Freemasons were in the Vatican. The Jews had a role. The pants were a plot. My mother, who had her own sharper instincts about a few of these claims, pushed back in private; but in public, beside my father on a Sunday morning in the union hall, she did not contradict him, and I grew up inside that silence.

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The theological disputes did not stop with our parents—I was doing my own version of my father's work on my friend Guy. Every night we'd discuss these issues on the phone. Words like "heresy," "Modernist," "infiltrator," were common refrains. Guy stood his ground. He loved the Church the way he loved everything in his life, with unbridled loyalty.

These tensions spilled over in an ugly round of teenage insults and Guy's thirteenth birthday sleepover at his house that ended with hard feelings. I made the mistake of telling my sister Lisa that Guy said, "You guys have so many kids because your dad sleeps with your sisters!" Lisa, who was then eighteen and carrying a secret of her own she had not yet told any of us, did not hear it as a boy's joke. She heard it the way you hear a line that crosses a line. She dropped her washcloth in the bathroom sink, marched into the kitchen, picked up the rotary phone, and called Guy.

"How dare you," she said into the receiver when Guy answered. "How dare you say such a horrible thing about our father."

What followed was a small-scale familial world war. That became the hill our friendship almost died on. Guy and I stopped speaking for months. Our mothers stopped speaking. I had lost my best friend over a dumb careless joke that escalated.

Chapter 8

Transformers

When I became a man I put away childish things, including the fear of childishness and the desire to be very grown up. —C.S. Lewis

Were it not for the intervention of our mutual friend Danny Farrell acting as diplomat, my friendship with Guy would have been lost forever over our ordeal. Guy came to the house one golden late-summer afternoon and apologized to me, and then—in a move that caught me off guard—to my father. The feud ended the way family feuds usually do: not with a verdict, but with a handshake that nobody had negotiated. That Fall, I began the seventh grade at St. John's Ukrainian Catholic School, where I had expected to find the same school I had attended since third grade. Instead, I discovered the same school with no nuns in it.

A lay teacher at St. John's had led some internal crusade that resulted in the nuns being sent back to their motherhouse in Washington D.C.—a decision my father, for reasons I didn't understand at the time, had supported, then almost immediately regretted upon realizing he'd been misled. The school Principal Sister Chrysanthemum had said to him on the way out: "I never thought you'd do this to us, Mr. Massett." That sentence stayed in him. I would see its shadow on his face at odd moments for months.

My new seventh-grade homeroom teacher was Mrs. Calucy, a lay Catholic, the sort my parents had never before allowed into their orbit. She announced to her students on the first day of religion class, brightly, that she did not know why women could not be priests.

I was only thirteen years old, but already well versed in apologetics. I raised my hand. "If Our Lord wanted women priests," I said, "don't you think He'd have ordained His own mother?"

Mrs. Calucy's mouth tightened. "Well, he didn't because it was against the customs of the time. People wouldn't have accepted it."

"Do you think He was afraid they might crucify Him?"

The class laughed. Mrs. Calucy did not. I told the story at dinner that night. My father did not laugh either. A week later he pulled us out of St. John's and enrolled us in Lakestreet Middle School, the local public school. Guy was at Lakestreet. I thought that was a good thing. It turned out not to be, at least not at first.

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In late May my sister Marie came home from her freshman year at St. Mary's Academy in Kansas. She had left Bridgeport the previous September at fifteen—a girl who loved pop music and dancing and had spent her afternoons turning our living room into a dance studio when our mother was out. She came back wearing a skirt. She no longer was interested in dance or the things we had in common. She'd become a "holy roller." I could not square the sister who had left with the sister who had returned. Her old best friend Angela, a high school cheerleader who had spent the year sitting next to me on the late bus asking about Marie when she lived too far away to call, tried to reconnect with her. Marie saw Angela exactly once, and then stopped returning her calls. When I asked Marie why, she said, "We've grown apart."

I spent mornings at summer school after bombing out in seventh grade. Ever since Sister Catherine, I hated every aspect of school. In the afternoons, Guy would come over in his boat and we'd water ski all afternoon while my parents' annoyance grew with my indifference to Fr. Williamson's Sunday denunciations of pants and rock music and "Americanism." I did not notice. I was fourteen, on the cusp of adulthood and independence.

One August afternoon I rolled my bike into our driveway and my father, who was pruning the young apple tree in the front yard, called me over without looking up from the clippers.

"Lou. Come here."

"Yeah?"

He didn't look at me. He kept clipping. "We can't handle you anymore. Your mother and I have decided to send you to St. Mary's this coming school year with your sister."

The rest of what he said went by me like static. I kept looking at the clippers in his hands and at the branches falling away from the tree. I wondered, vaguely, if he noticed the irony of what he was pruning. I wondered, less vaguely, which specific thing I had done that had earned me this. The fight? The grades? The rock music? Taping over his Confirmation video with Syracuse's 1987 NCAA tournament run—the tape he had treated as a holy relic, over which he had raged at me that I valued basketball over faith? He never clarified. He never clarified anything. That was the first lesson I learned that afternoon about the kind of authority my father had become: it did not feel the need to account for itself, and therefore could not be reasoned with.

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A week later, I earned thirty-five dollars digging a drainage ditch for our neighbor Mr. Pauls under the worst August sun of my life. The next morning my mother took me to the mall and I spent every cent on the five Transformers that combined into Superion, the foot-tall robot I had been circling at the display for months. When she asked me in the Price Chopper parking lot to hand over the money so she could buy food for my going-away party, I held up Superion in the passenger seat and said *THIS happened*. My mother tsked. "Wait until your father gets home."

My father, when he got home, came into my bedroom with an expression I did not recognize. He told me to hand over every Transformer I owned. He said the thing I have not been able to forget in the thirty-eight years since. He said I was, in the specific phrase he chose, "nigger rich." He said I was too old for toys. He gathered every robot I owned off my desk and out of my closet, and he carried them out of the room in both arms. He took them into the den at the back of the house and locked the door.

I sat on my bed. Something shifted in me that had not previously shifted. It was the first time I had ever felt about my father what I would, over the next twenty-five years, learn how to feel about him more and more often: a cold, hard resentment that did not move, that did not want to be talked out of, that had its own geometry. I resolved, sitting on that bed, to build a wall between us. It took me a long time to admit to myself that I had succeeded.

My parents ultimately relented and decided not to cancel the going-away party, though the hosting of it had the energy of a funeral. My friends came. They stood around on the back lawn. Guy was quieter than I'd ever known him. My brother Jarred—with whom, in the last year, I had finally begun to play basketball as equals—came with his family. Lisa was there, quiet in the way she was always quiet now, post-wedding. Jarred's three-year-old daughter tugged at my sleeve in the kitchen and looked up and asked, "Why are your eyes so red, Uncle Lou?"

I didn't want to say.

On the morning we left, as my parents loaded the van, I ran back inside claiming I had forgotten something. I went down the hall to my father's den with a butter knife and jimmied the lock to get in. The Transformers were in a cardboard box on top of his bookcase. I loaded Superion and the rest into my green carry-on, relocked the door, and climbed back into the van. My mother looked at me. "Got everything you need?" I met

her eyes. I nodded. I think she knew. I think some part of her was proud. I will never know.

When the United Airlines flight to Kansas City lifted off the runway I felt the particular zero-gravity of my fourteen-year-old body being taken somewhere against its will, and I understood for the first time that the world was a place you could be sent to. Marie sat next to me. I reached into my carry-on and pulled Superion out of it and held it up between us.

"You want to see something?"

Her eyes went wide. "How did you *get* that?"

"I have my ways."

"You are going to be in *so* much trouble."

"What do you think they'll do," I said, mock-terrified, my voice quivering. "Send me away to boarding school?"

Marie half-laughed, half-rolled her eyes, and went back to her magazine. The plane leveled out. I put Superion back in the bag. I did not play with Superion ever again after that flight, which was a fact I did not yet know.

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At the Topeka airport we were met by a blonde nineteen-year-old college student named Caroline whose smile was the brightest thing I had encountered in the state of Kansas. She hugged Marie. She hugged me. "Marie's told me how fun and talented you are," she said to me. "Are you funny too?"

"Are we talking about the same Marie?"

Caroline laughed as though I had just handed her something precious. "You ARE funny." If St. Mary's Academy had a brand ambassador in 1987, it was this girl. In the car she narrated the virtues of the place at full speed for thirty minutes—Fr. Herve De la Tour, the library, the chapel, the boys' gym, the Jesuit buildings—while the Kansas landscape opened around us in a flat, gold endlessness I had never before seen the sky look that big above.

When we pulled into St. Mary's I was not ready. The campus was stopped in time. A white statue of the Blessed Mother stood at the entrance roundabout in front of the charred black remains of the Immaculata Chapel, a cathedral the town had lost to a fire in 1980 and never rebuilt. The quad behind the Immaculata was the size of two football fields, framed by limestone and red-brick Jesuit buildings whose windows were still gridded the way they had been when the Society of Jesus had taught here before the Depression. It looked, in the late-afternoon light, like a mirage. It looked like something I had seen in a dream.

Caroline drove up the hill to the girls' side and dropped Marie off. Marie grabbed her bags, bolted, and was twenty yards into the grass when Caroline called after her: "Marie, aren't you going to say goodbye to your brother?" My sister turned back briefly. "Oh—yeah, sorry, Louie. I'll see you later."

"When?"

"They'll let us know."

"What do you mean? I can't walk up and get you?"

The answer was already walking away from me across a sunlit lawn. It took me another forty-five minutes of being walked around the boys' side of campus by Mr. Thomas—the Head Housefather, a man of about fifty in coke-bottle glasses and a wrinkled OP t-shirt—to understand that the separation between the boys' and the girls'

sides was not a matter of a bike ride. It was a cloistered separation. The dorms were on opposite ends of the campus. Every contact between boys and girls was mediated by a housefather. I could not, as I had imagined on the plane, walk up to Marie's dorm and knock on the door and say hi. I could see her at Mass. At Vespers. In the cafeteria — across a room. I could not, if I was honest with myself, reach her.

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That afternoon Mr. Thomas walked me through the list of what I could not bring onto campus or keep in my locker: no Walkman, no rock music, no boom boxes, no radios, no secular magazines. I surrendered the Walkman I had stashed in my bag. He did not mention the Transformers. He did not think to ask, and I did not tell him. In the cavernous eighth-grade dorm room—fifty feet long, forty feet wide, nine metal bunk beds around its perimeter, cathedral ceilings—I met Darren Cramner, my Prefect, a junior who would wake me each morning of that school year by knocking on the foot of my bunk and saying *Benedicamus Domino* in a tone of voice I came to recognize in my sleep. I was supposed to respond *Deo Gratias*—let us bless the Lord, thanks be to God—a ritual handoff whose Latin I would eventually memorize. That first morning I mumbled "Yeah," and Darren corrected me. "You have to respond *Deo Gratias*." I nodded. I was fourteen. I was beginning to understand that I had been moved, in a single week, out of the country I had grown up in and into a country that spoke a dead language.

At 9:30 p.m. the first night, Mr. Thomas gathered us in the third-floor prayer room for Night Prayers. Forty middle-school boys knelt on linoleum in the fluorescent light, reading in unison from a printed booklet whose cover had been worn down to the grain of the cardboard. The Latin moved over my head. When we stood, Mr. Thomas told us to observe Grand Silence—no talking to anyone, dorm-mate or housefather, until after Mass the next morning. I climbed into my bunk in the silence. I could hear forty other

boys not-talking. I could hear the prairie wind push against the leaded windows. I was a long way from Oneida Lake.

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The next morning I survived the two-hour Solemn High Mass on a growling stomach and left the chapel believing—with the optimism that sometimes follows exhaustion—that the day had to get better. It did, briefly, in the afternoon. Darren knocked on my door and asked if I wanted to play pickup basketball at the gym. I had brought sneakers in my carry-on. I had not thought I would get to use them. The gym, when Darren opened the doors, was a church of its own—fifteen high-school and college boys running half-court pickup under the fluorescent lights, sneakers squeaking on varnished wood—and my eighth-grade teacher Mr. Hollis, who turned out to be a University of Rhode Island alum who had once had a Celtics tryout, was draining fifteen-foot jumpers from the baseline as if it were the easiest thing anyone had ever done. When teams were picked, he picked me. I played the best pick-and-roll I had in me. He said, "Nice move, Massett." For two hours I was home again.

Then I drank from the water fountain and the water was wrong. St. Mary's sat on a limestone aquifer. The water tasted metallic and slightly oily, and in the August heat of a Kansas town I had not known the temperatures of, it made me gag. I drank it anyway. I had no choice. An hour later Mr. Thomas came to collect me for Vespers.

"Vespers? What's that?"

"You'll see. Change. Chapel dress code."

I will spare the reader the full liturgical choreography of what followed. Vespers was a sung Latin Office of twenty-five minutes for which we stood and sat and stood and sat in a pattern I could not predict. When it ended, I thought it was over. It was not. The sacristy bell rang, the organ started again, and a priest processed to the altar

carrying the Blessed Sacrament in a monstrance. The congregation began to sing a slow Latin hymn I did not know. Benediction. Another twenty-five minutes. I was hungry. I was dehydrated from the limestone water. I was fourteen years old and I had already prayed for something like five hours that day, and the beauty of what was unfolding around me—the chant, the gold, the incense, the ancient choreography of the Church's evening prayer—was entirely, completely, utterly lost on me. I was miserable.

That night while my bunkmates unpacked, Mr. Novak—the eighth-grade housefather, a lanky recent college graduate—asked me to help him swap out a busted mattress for one of my roommates. The spare mattresses were kept in a large storage room behind our dorm, a twenty-by-twenty-five-foot space cluttered with old bed frames and spare bunk pieces and yellowed mattresses stacked three deep. He did not notice my eyes adjusting. I did. I saw it the way a certain kind of boy sees things. It was a hiding place.

Five minutes before Vespers on the second Sunday of the school year, I slipped into that back room and stacked mattresses into a little alcove the size of a crouched twelve-year-old, crawled in, and listened through the floor to forty of my classmates kneeling one story below me in the chapel, singing through the Rosary, then Vespers, then Benediction. I did not attend Vespers again for the rest of that year. I kept a small stash in the fort—comic books, old magazines, snacks from town day on Thursdays. For fifty minutes each Sunday I was, in my mattress fort, the freest boy in the state of Kansa